



CHARLES
UNIVERSITY

Estimating Vegetation Change from Fossil Pollen to Planetary Boundaries

A Global, Long-Term Synthesis Using Big Data



 Ondřej Mottl

TIBS 2026

Scan the QR code to follow along!





6/9 global Earth Planetary
Boundaries are already exceeded

(Richardson et al. 2023) *Science Advances*

Image generated by Bing



~20%

*Species to be exposed to **dangerous temperature** condition (with global increase of 2.0°C)*

IPCC AR6 Synthesis Report

Image by Justus Menke from Pexels



What if ...



... we inform the
conservation policies by
incorporating a **global,**
long-term synthesis on
ecosystem dynamics using
paleoecological **Big Data**?

 **Hi! I am Ondřej Mottl**



Assistant Professor at  Charles University, Prague, cz

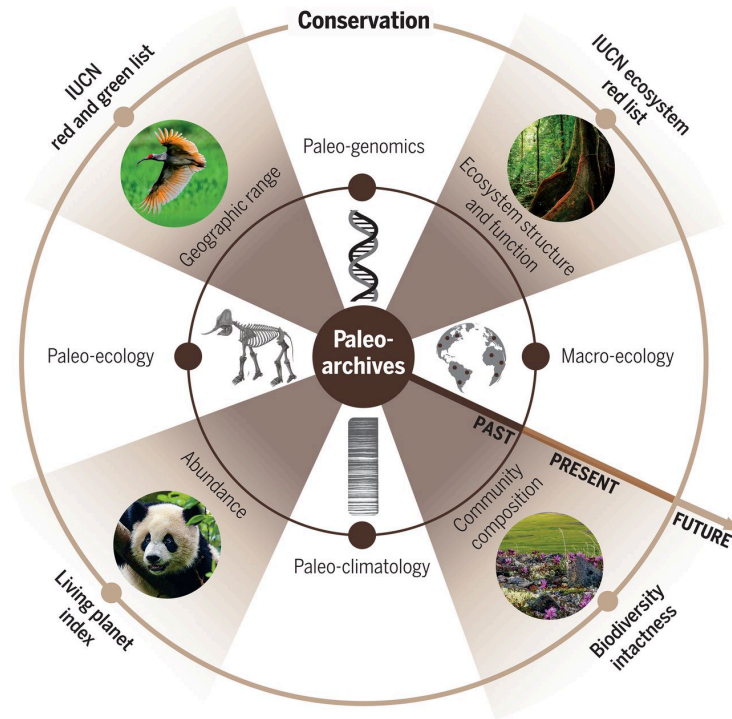
Interested in macroecology, palaeoecology, biodiversity, and data science

Head of the  Laboratory of Quantitative Ecology

-  [ondrej.mottl\(at\)natur.cuni.cz](mailto:ondrej.mottl(at)natur.cuni.cz)
-  ondrej.mottl.bsky.social
-  [Github](https://github.com/ondrej.mottl)
-  [ORCID](https://orcid.org/ondrej.mottl)
-  [Personal webpage](https://www.ondrej.mottl.cz)



Palaeoecology



Science

HOME > SCIENCE > VOL. 369, NO. 6507 > USING PALEO-ARCHIVES TO SAFEGUARD BIODIVERSITY UNDER CLIMATE CHANGE

Using paleo-archives to safeguard biodiversity under climate change

DAMIEN A. FORDHAM , STEPHEN T. JACKSON , STUART C. BROWN , BRIAN HUNTLEY , BARRY W. BROOK , DORTHE DAHL-JENSEN, M. THOMAS P. GILBERT

, BETTE L. OTTO-BLIESNER , ANDERS SVENSSON , [...], AND DAVID NOGUES-BRAVO [+8 authors](#) [Authors Info & Affiliations](#)

SCIENCE • 28 Aug 2020 • Vol 369, Issue 6507 • DOI: 10.1126/science.abc5654

Because **warning signals** ... are commonly identified by using time-series ... data, **paleo-archives** provide opportunities to **test conservation criteria** ...



Fossil pollen as a
window to the past
vegetation patterns

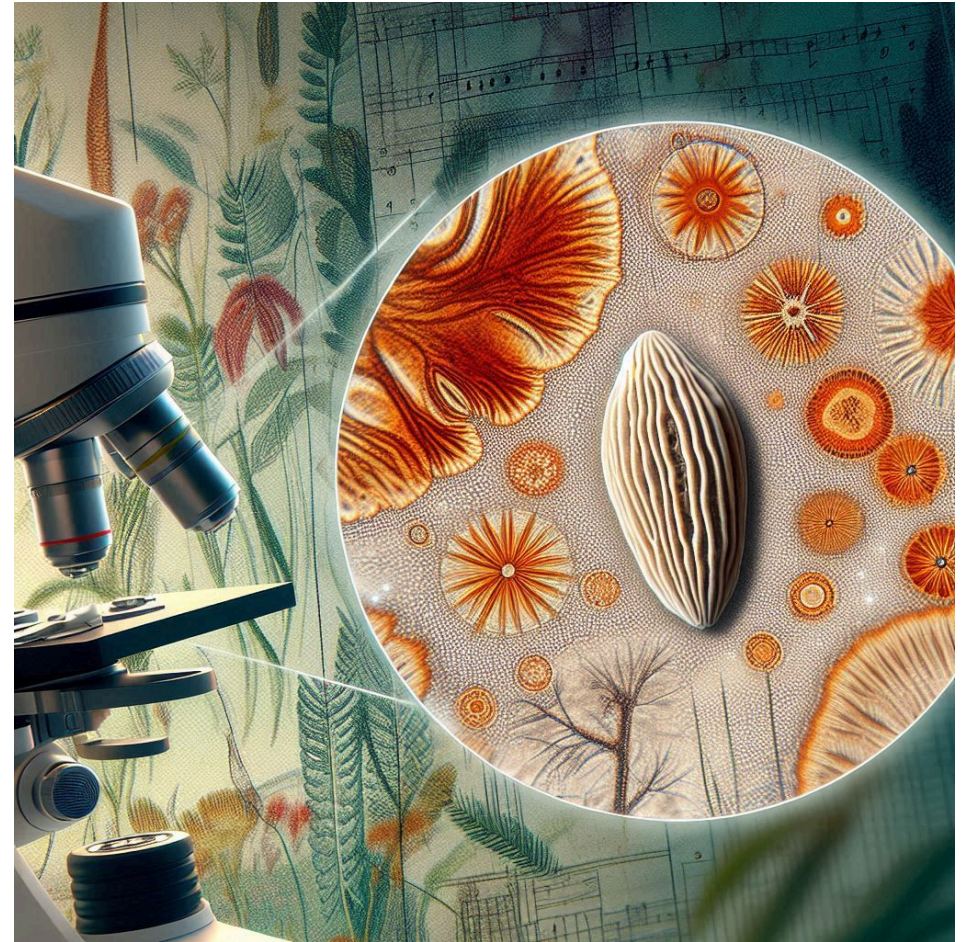


Image created by Bing



Neotoma Paleoecology Database

> 6650

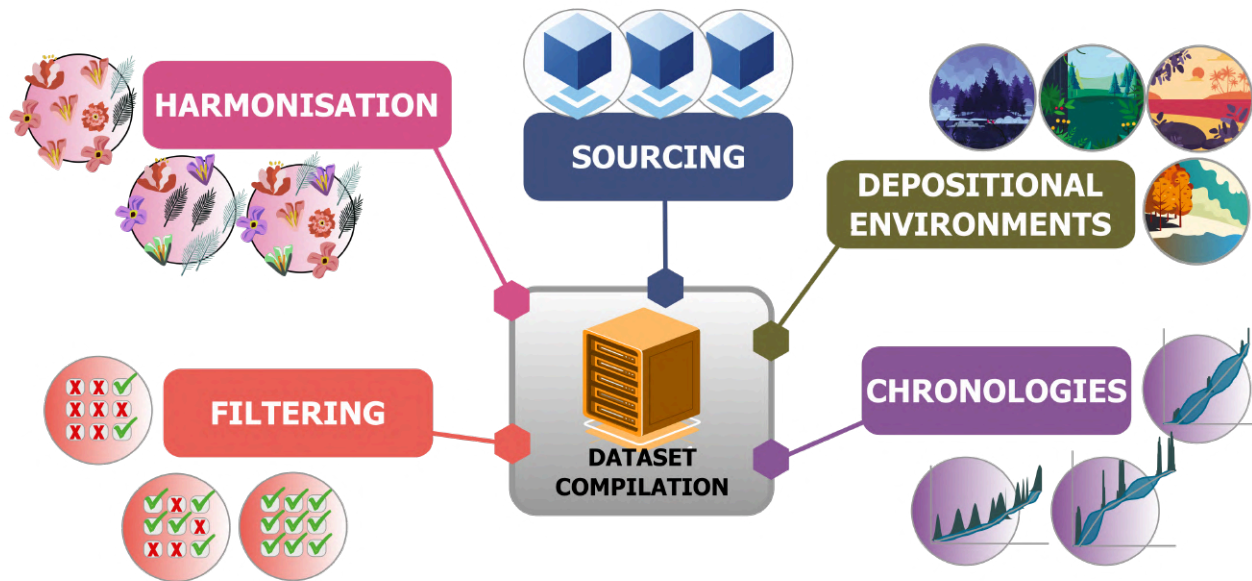
fossil pollen timeseries (records)



Fossil pollen datasets accessed from [Neotoma](#) on 2025-12-09



Palaeoecological dataset compilation

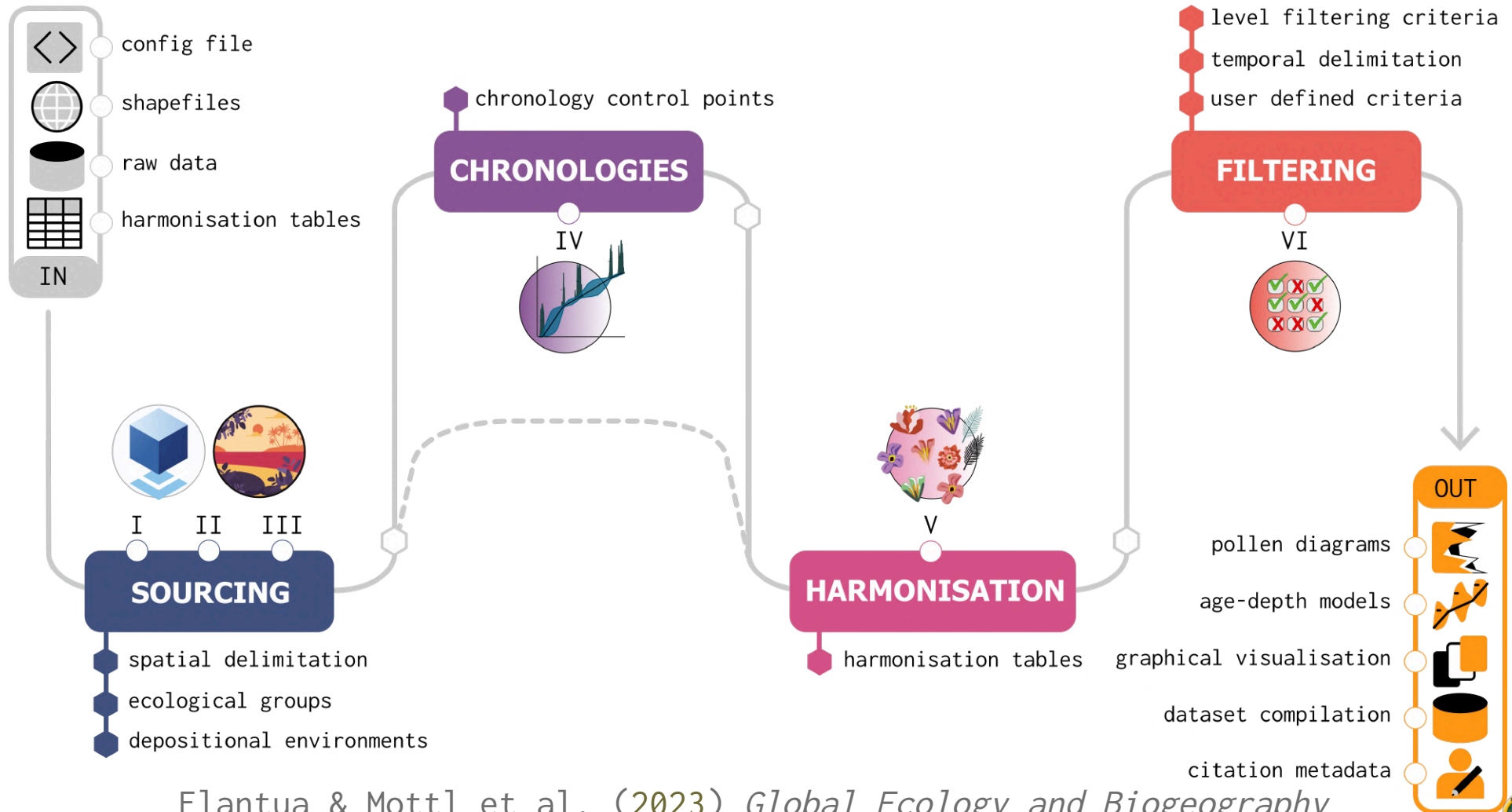


- Macro-scale data analysis
- Project specific
- Data quality control and reproducibility



The workflow to process
global palaeoecological data
of fossil pollen for
vegetation-based
macroecological synthesis

FOSSILPOL workflow



Documentation (website)



PUBLISHED
February 22, 2022

MODIFIED
March 12, 2025

FOSSILPOL project

Summary

This website presents all information needed about the FOSSILPOL workflow that aims to process and standardise global palaeoecological pollen data.

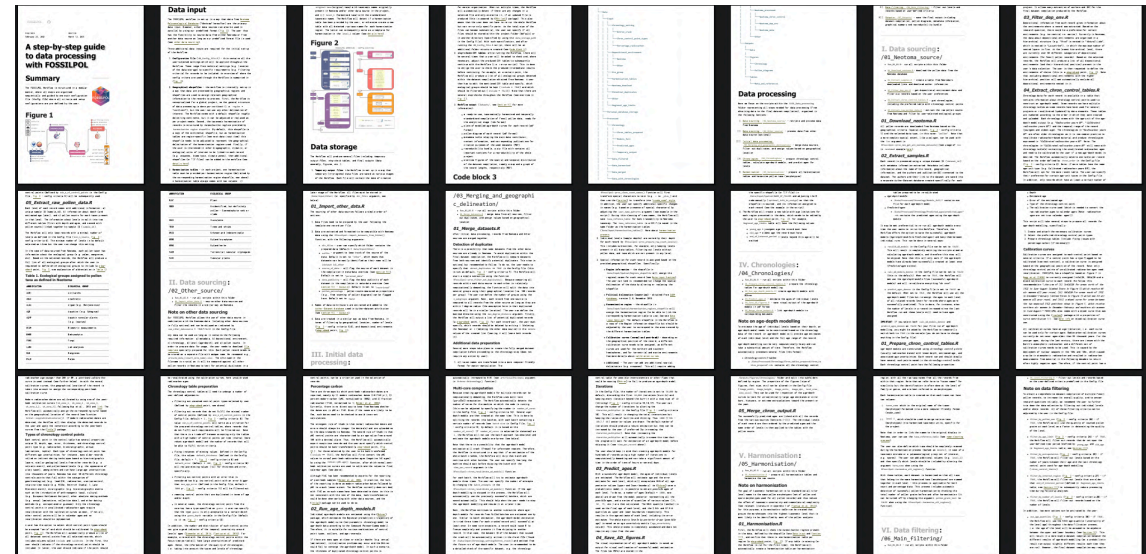
Authors

The FOSSILPOL workflow has been developed during the ERC project called the *Humans on Planet Earth (HOPE)* team at the *University of Bergen*:

Suzette G.A. Flantua*, Ondrej Mottl*, Vivian Felde*, Kuber P. Bhatta*, Hilary Birks, John-Arvid Grytnes, Alistair Seddon, H. John B. Birks

* shared first authors

Ondrej Mottl is the main maintainer of the FOSSILPOL project



Now bilingual! (English / Spanish)

Check it out! - bit.ly/FOSSILPOL

Flantua & Mottl et al. (2023) *Global Ecology and Biogeography*



FOSSILPOL



- Open-source and reproducible workflow written in R
- Handles all the steps and flags places, where the user needs to specify their choices
- Modular structure to allow flexibility and customisation for different projects



**Global Ecology
and Biogeography**

A Journal of
Macroecology

METHOD | Open Access |

**A guide to the processing and standardization of global
palaeoecological data for large-scale syntheses using
fossil pollen**

[Suzette G. A. Flantua](#) , [Ondrej Mottl](#), [Vivian A. Felde](#), [Kuber P. Bhatta](#), [Hilary H. Birks](#),
[John-Arvid Grytnes](#), [Alistair W. R. Seddon](#), [H. John B. Birks](#)

First published: 02 May 2023 | <https://doi.org/10.1111/geb.13693>



FOSSILPOL



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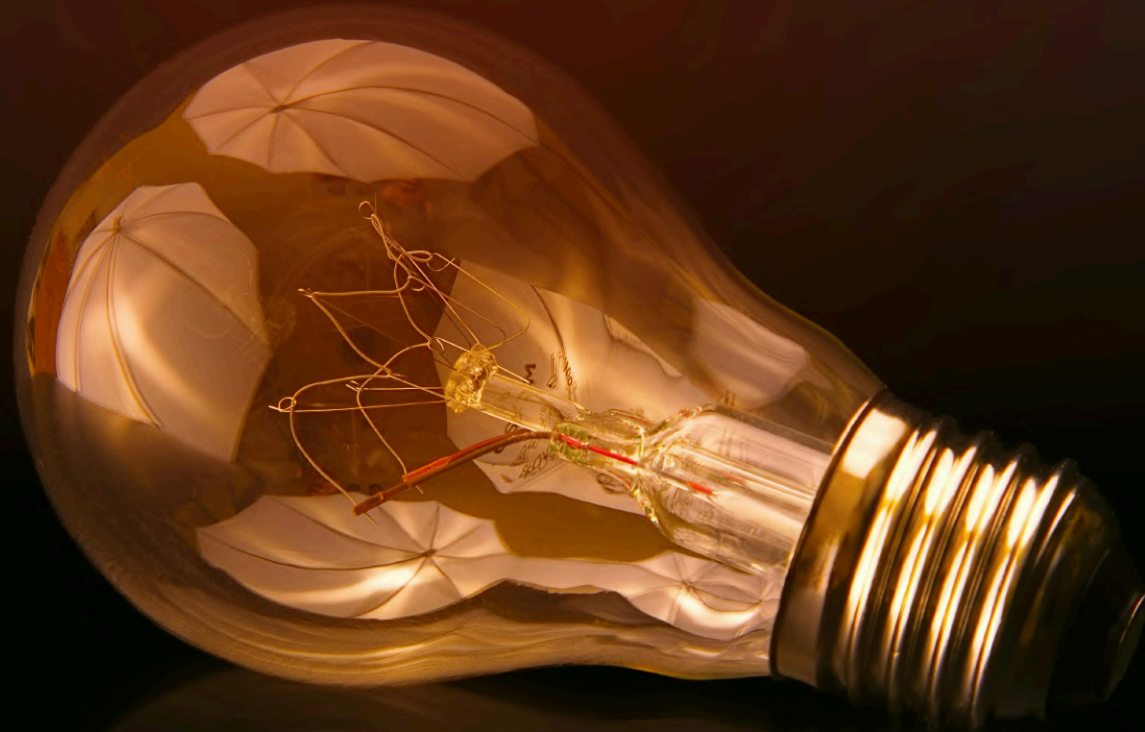
METHOD | Open Access |

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[Suzette G. A. Flantua](#) [Ondřej Mottl](#), [Vivian A. Felde](#), [Kuber P. Bhatta](#), [Hilary H. Birks](#),
[John-Arvid Grytnes](#), [Alistair W. R. Seddon](#), [H. John B. Birks](#)

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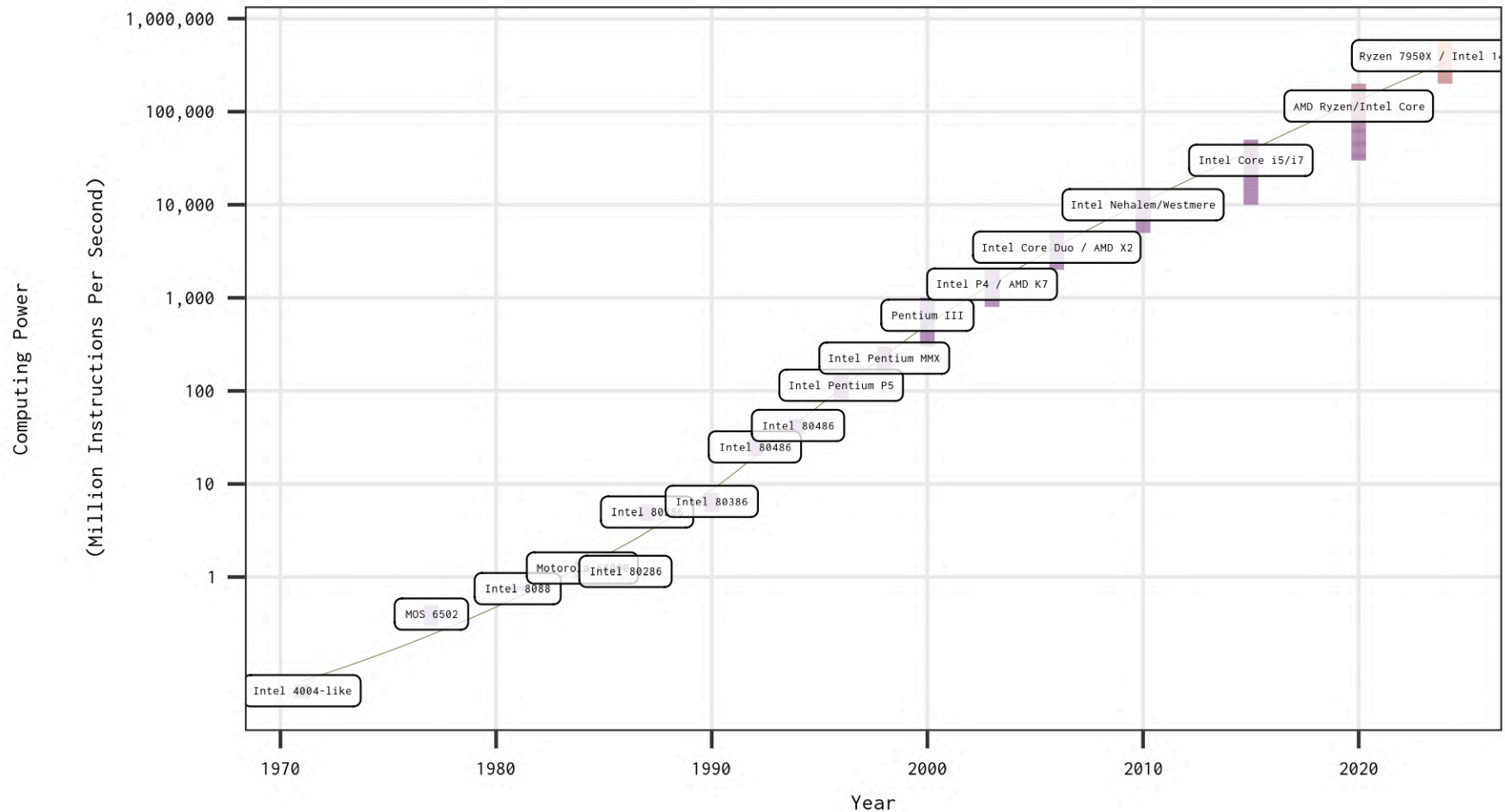


Inovations

Image by Johannes Plenio from Pexels



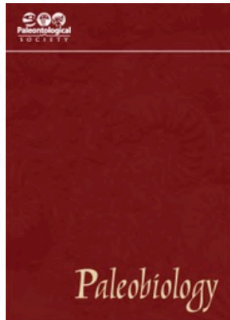
The power of a personal computer



The data obtained from [wikipedia/Instructions_per_second](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Instructions_per_second)



Analytical palaeoecology



Challenges and directions in analytical paleobiology

Published online by Cambridge University Press: 27 February 2023

Erin M. Dillon , Emma M. Dunne , Tom M. Womack ,
Miranta Kouvari, Ekaterina Larina, Jordan Ray Claytor,
Angelina Ivkić, Mark Juhn, Pablo S. Milla Carmona  and
Selina Viktor Robson ...Show all authors ▾



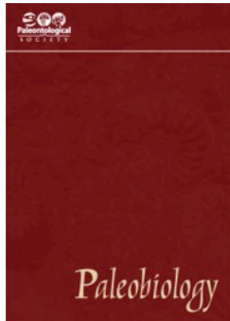
Advancements

Best practices and **reproducible workflows** for data standardization, Analyses that can accommodate **heterogeneous datasets**, Incentive structures that reward **software development**, Awareness of sampling context and biases, Best practices and conceptual frameworks to guide data integration, Development of taxon-free metrics, **Training** in quantitative methods and **Data Science**, Collaboration with data scientists, **Interdisciplinary** communication, collaboration, and funding

Dillon et al. (2023) *Paleobiology*



Analytical palaeoecology



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Advancements

Best practices and **reproducible workflows** for data standardization, Analyses that can accommodate **heterogeneous datasets**, Incentive structures that reward **software development**, Awareness of sampling context and biases, Best practices and conceptual frameworks to guide data integration, Development of taxon-free metrics, **Training** in quantitative methods and **Data Science**, Collaboration with data scientists, **Interdisciplinary** communication, collaboration, and funding

Erin Dillon has a talk directly after me!

Dillon et al. (2023) *Paleobiology*



Statistical advancements

New methods accounting for **effort**, **bias**, and **uncertainty**



Photo by [Andrea Piacquadio](#) from Pexels



Statistical advancements

New methods accounting for **effort**, **bias**, and **uncertainty**

- Hierarchical regression models
- Joined Species Distribution Models (jSDM)
- Model-based ordinations
- Copula methods
- ...



Photo by [Andrea Piacquadio](#) from Pexels



Statistical advancements

New methods accounting for **effort**, **bias**, and **uncertainty**

- Hierarchical regression models
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- Model-based ordinations
- Copula methods
- ...



More details in a moment in talk by **Gavin Simpson** in this Symposium!

Photo by [Andrea Piacquadio](#) from Pexels



Estimating Rate of Change (RoC)

Issues with palaeoecological RoC estimation

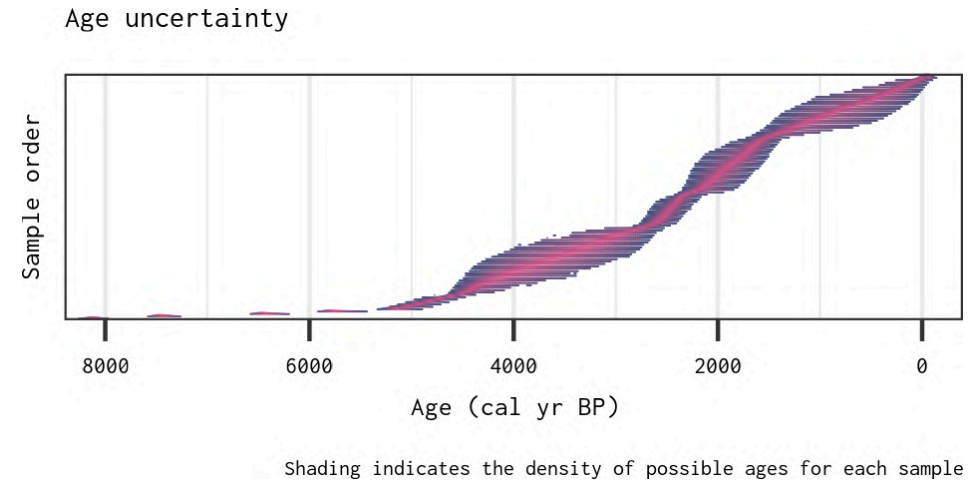


Estimating Rate of Change (RoC)

example data

Issues with palaeoecological RoC estimation

- Age uncertainties

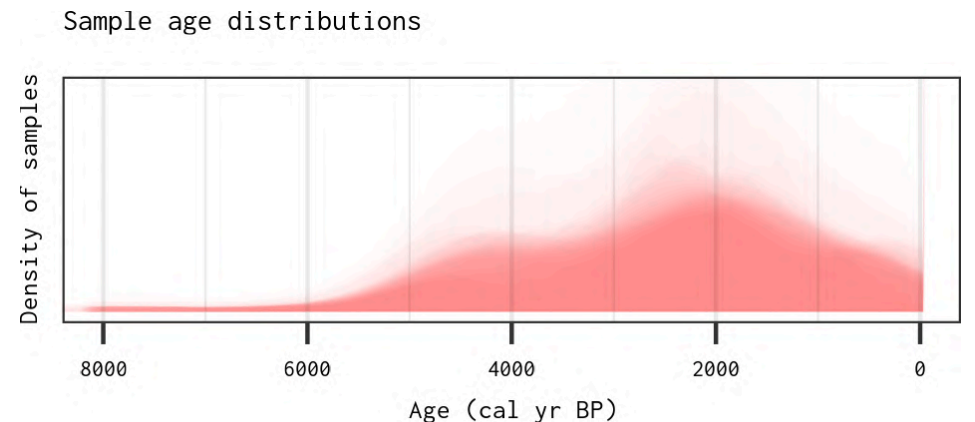
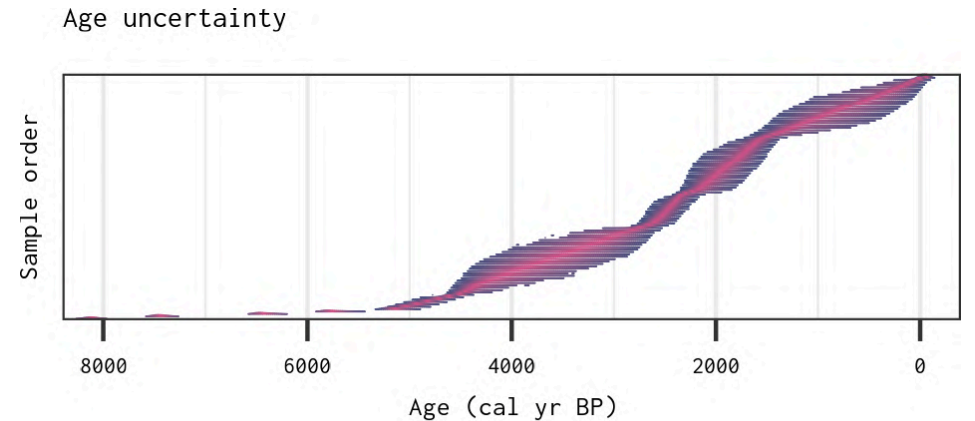


Estimating Rate of Change (RoC)

example data

Issues with palaeoecological RoC estimation

- Age uncertainties
- Uneven temporal distribution of samples



Density plots of possible ages for 100 random iterations

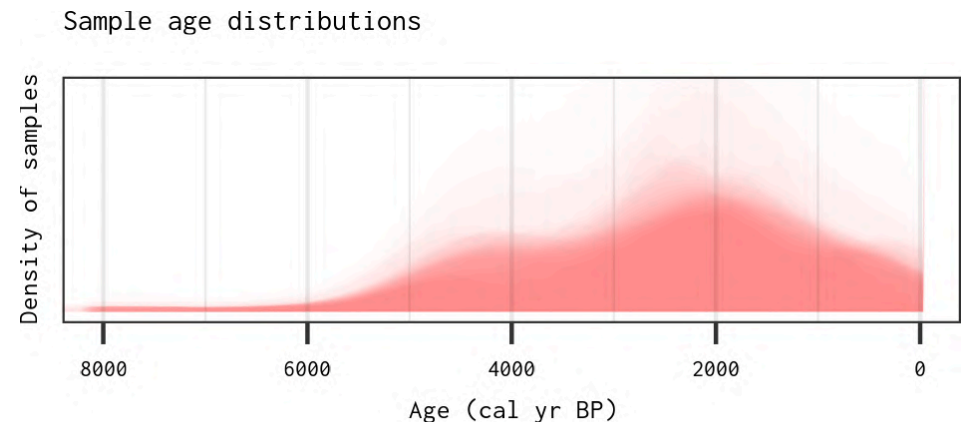
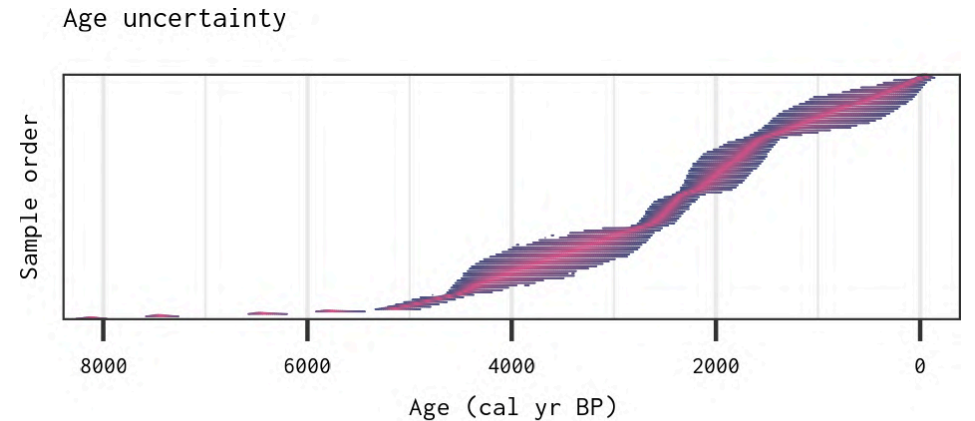


Estimating Rate of Change (RoC)

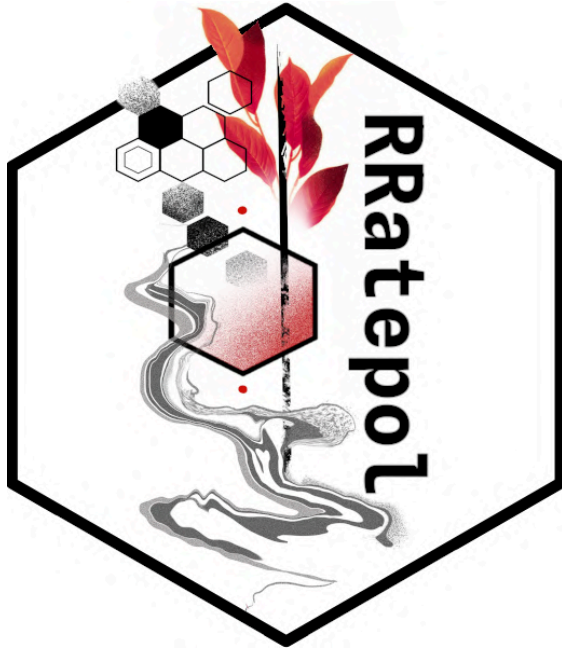
example data

Issues with palaeoecological RoC estimation

- Age uncertainties
- Uneven temporal distribution of samples
- Taxonomic uncertainties



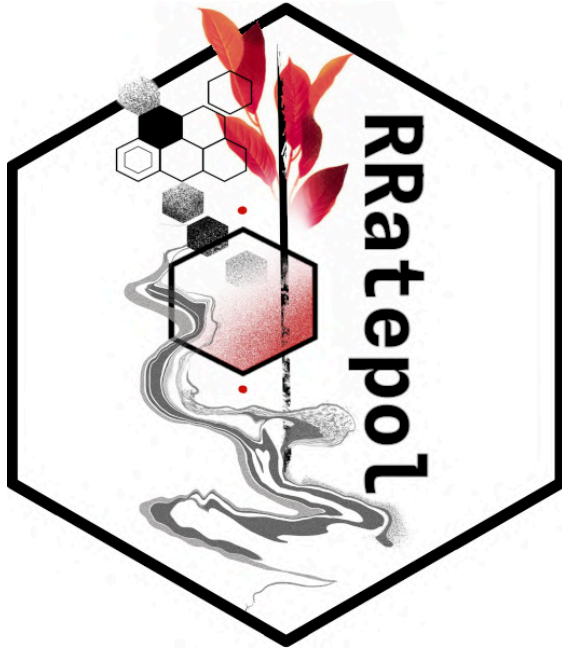
{RRatepol}



An R package for estimating **rate of change** (RoC) from **multivariate** (community) data in **time series**



{RRatepol}

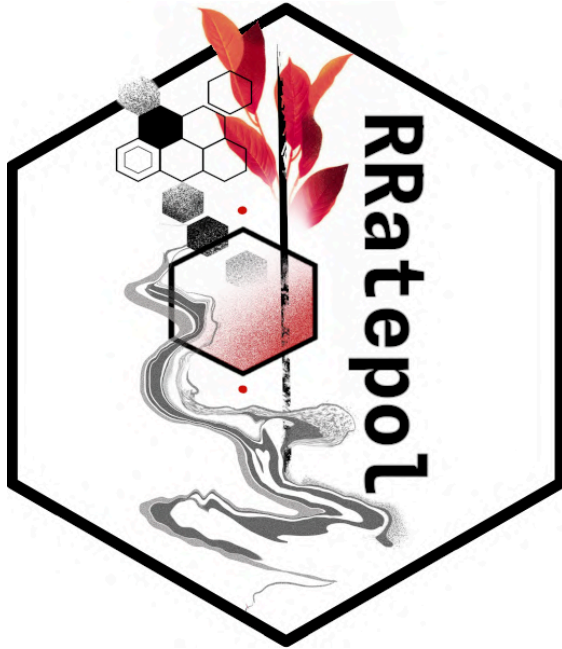


An R package for estimating **rate of change** (RoC) from **multivariate** (community) data in **time series**

- Handles **uneven time series**



{RRatepol}

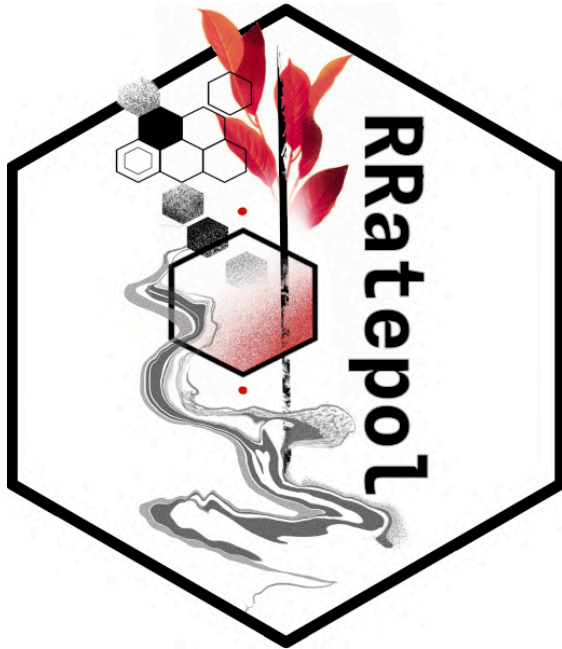


An R package for estimating **rate of change** (RoC) from **multivariate** (community) data in **time series**

- Handles **uneven time series**
- **Propagates uncertainty** (age, taxonomic)



{RRatepol}

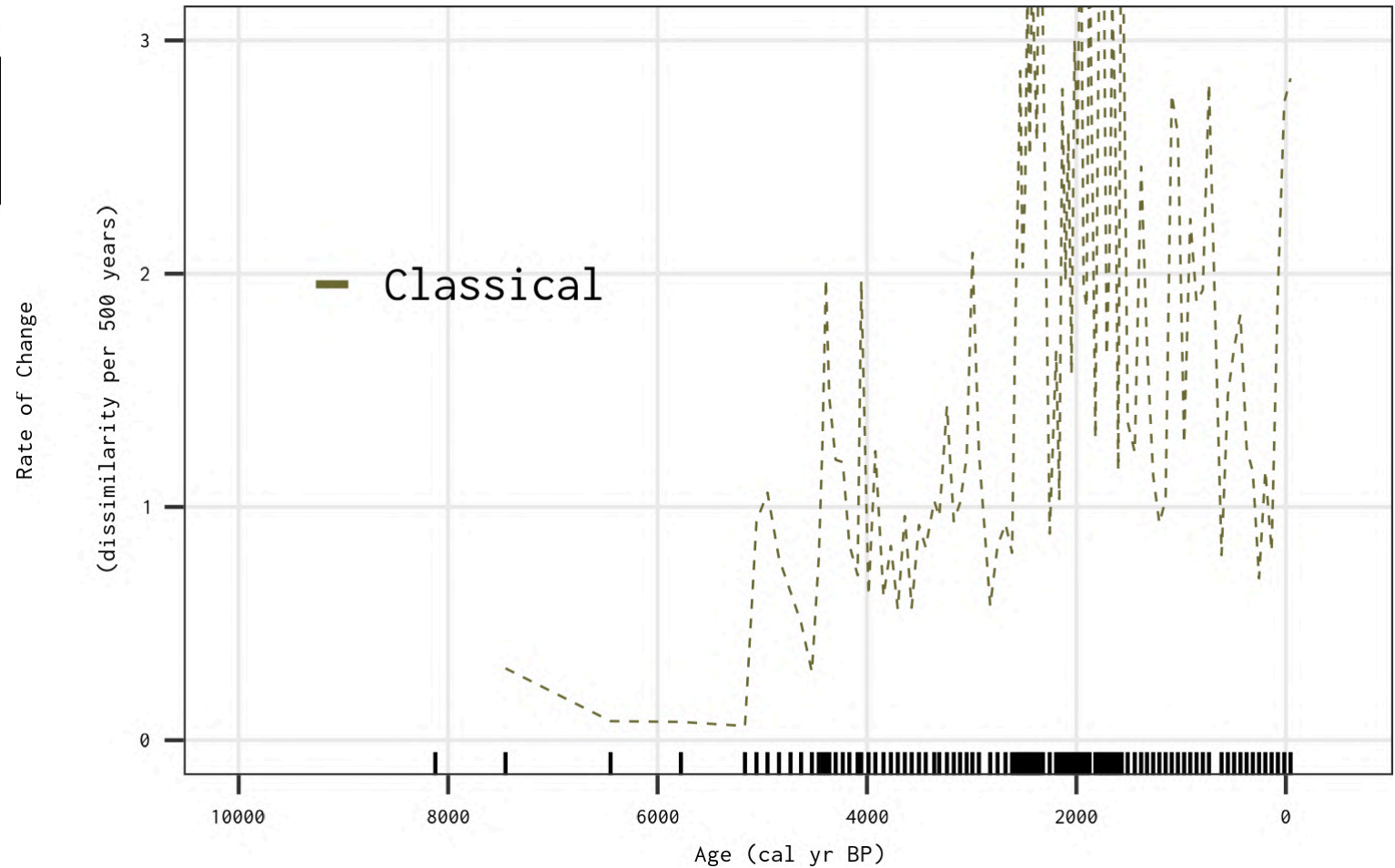


An R package for estimating **rate of change** (RoC) from **multivariate** (community) data in **time series**

- Handles **uneven time series**
- **Propagates uncertainty** (age, taxonomic)
- Can work with **various data types** (palaeoecological proxies)



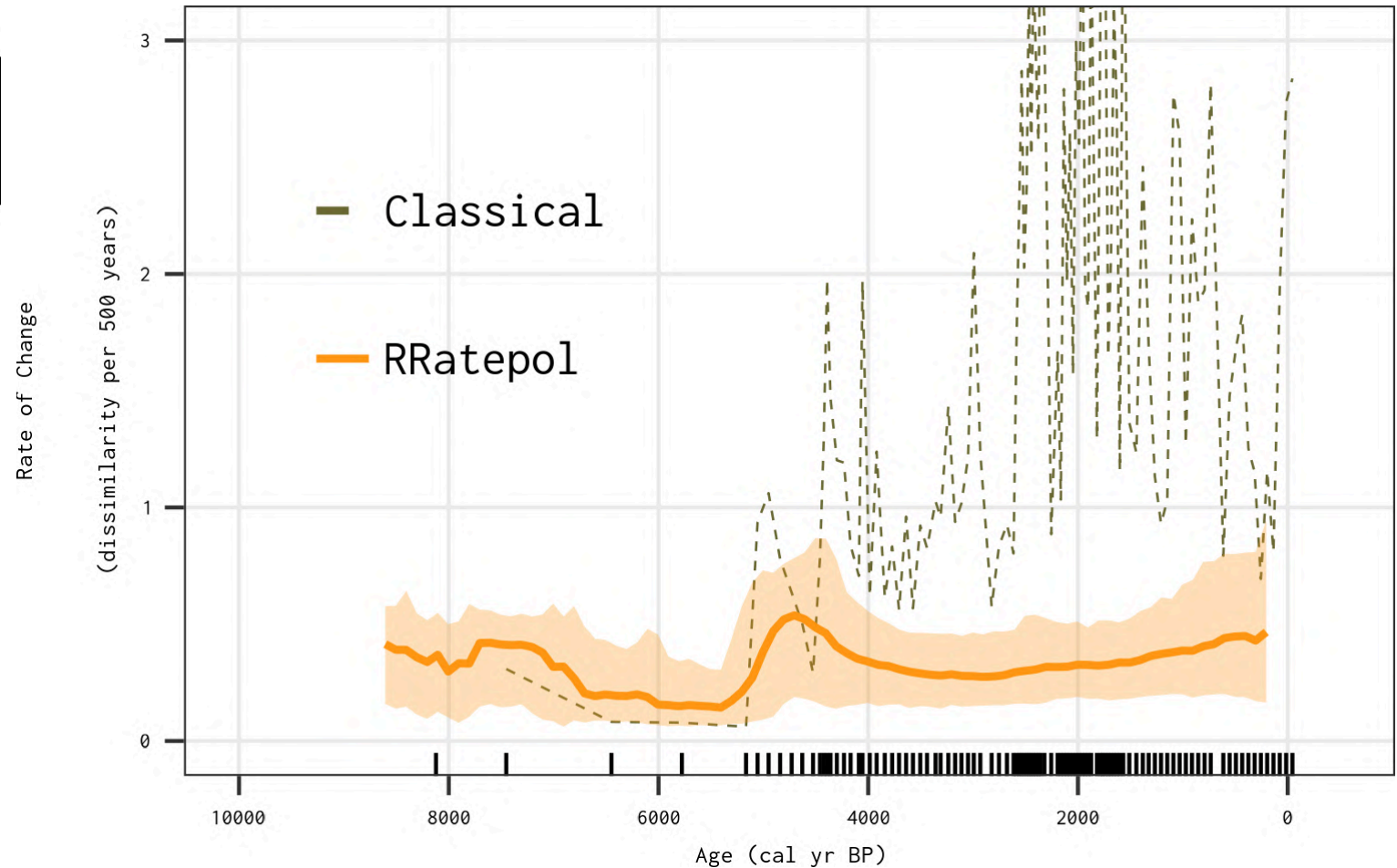
{RRatepol}



Mottl et al. ([2021](#)) *Review of Palaeobotany and Palynology*



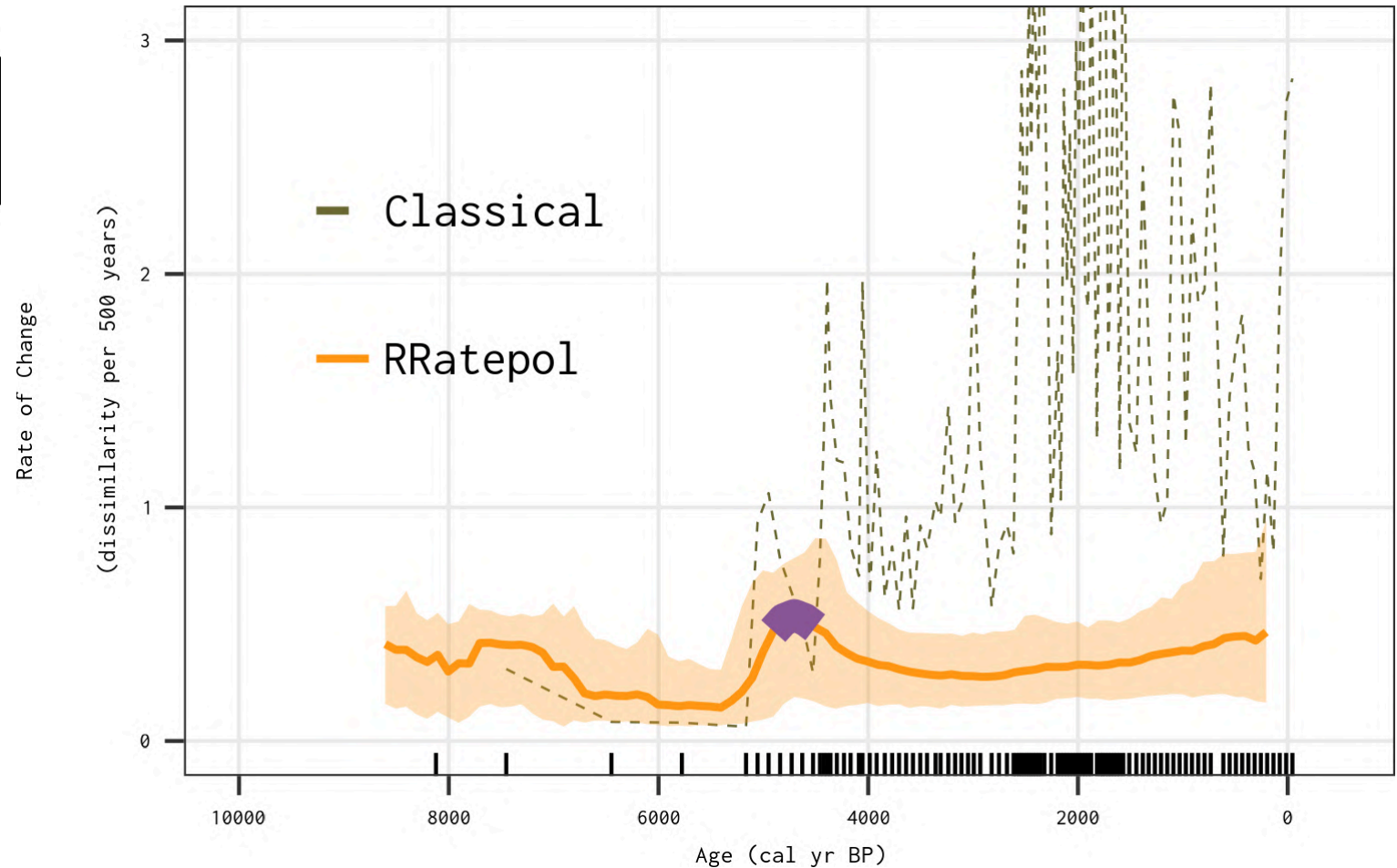
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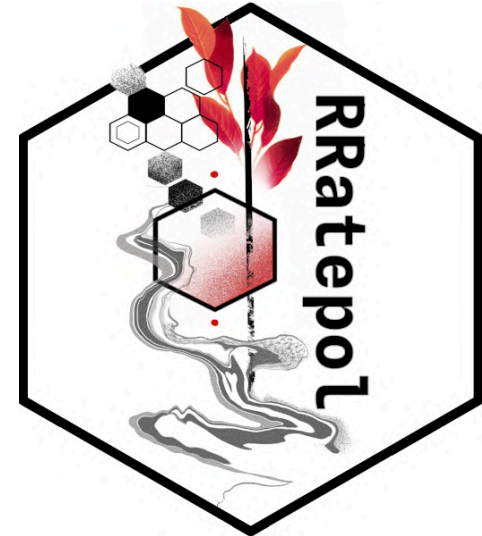
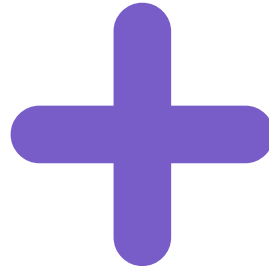
Mottl et al. ([2021](#)) *Review of Palaeobotany and Palynology*



Global rates of vegetation change over the past 18,000 years

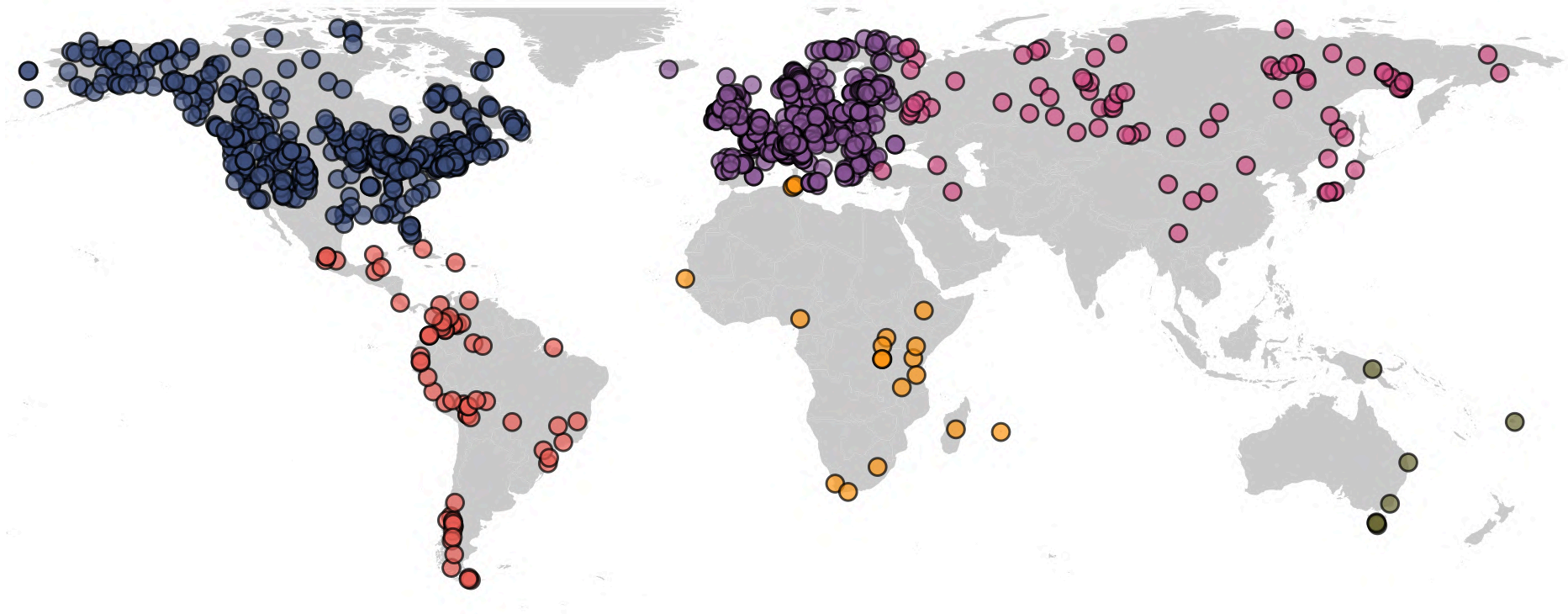


Global assembly of fossil
pollen records



Estimation of rate of
vegetation change

Global rates of vegetation change



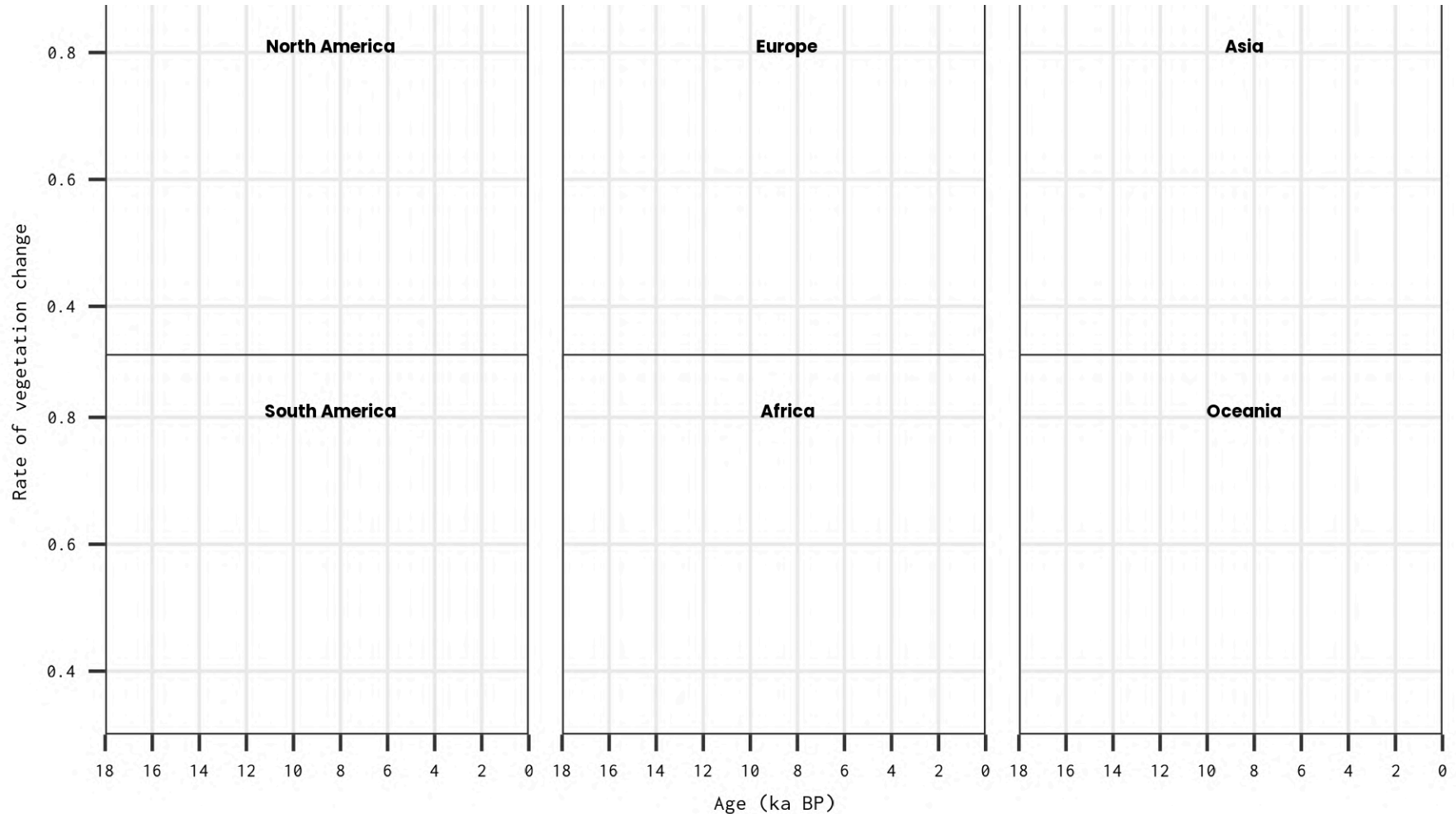
Over 1100 fossil pollen time series from all continents

(except Antarctica)

Adapted from Mottl & Flantua et al. ([2021](#)) *Science*



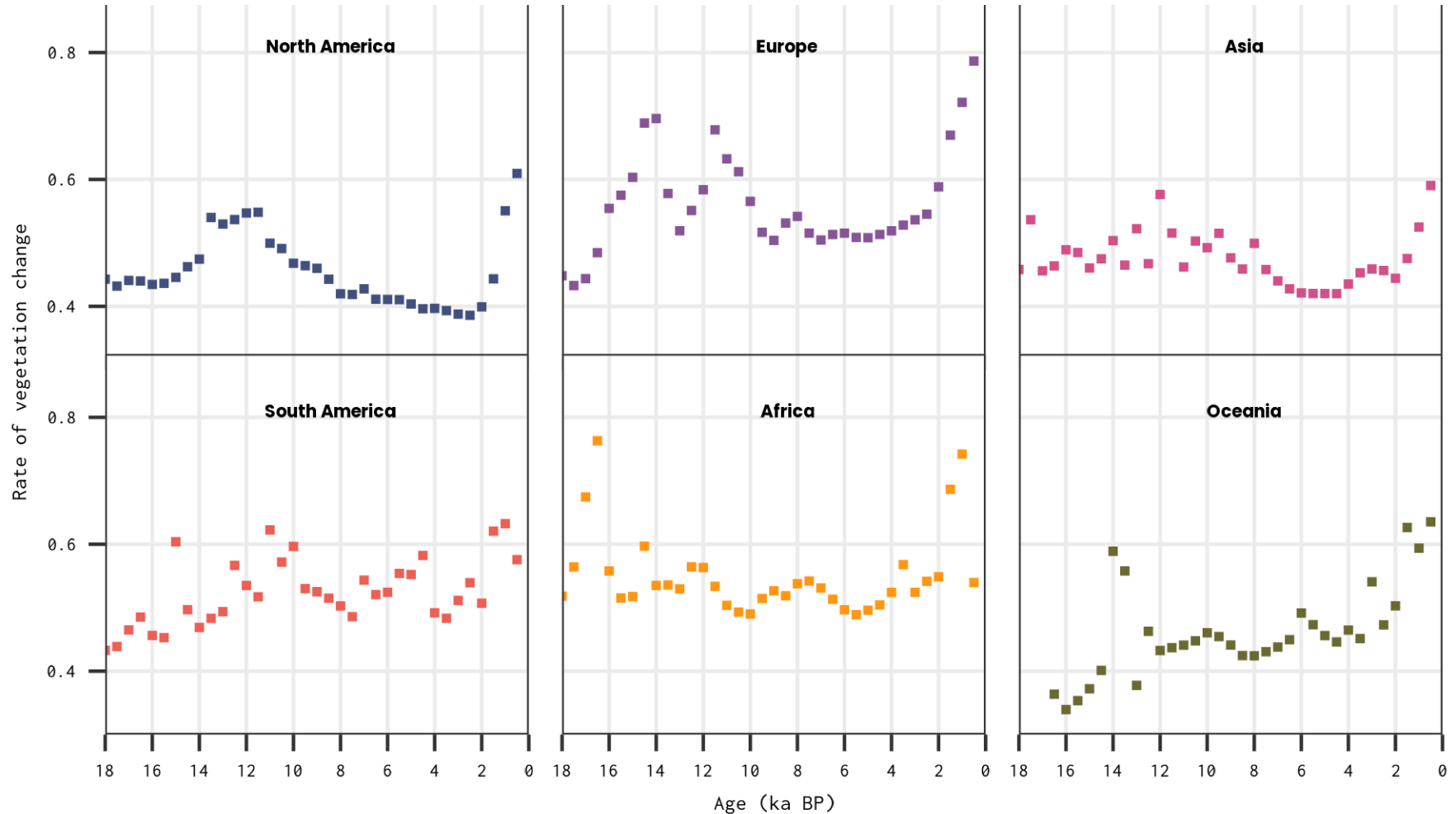
Global rates of vegetation change



Adapted from Mottl & Flantua et al. ([2021](#)) *Science*



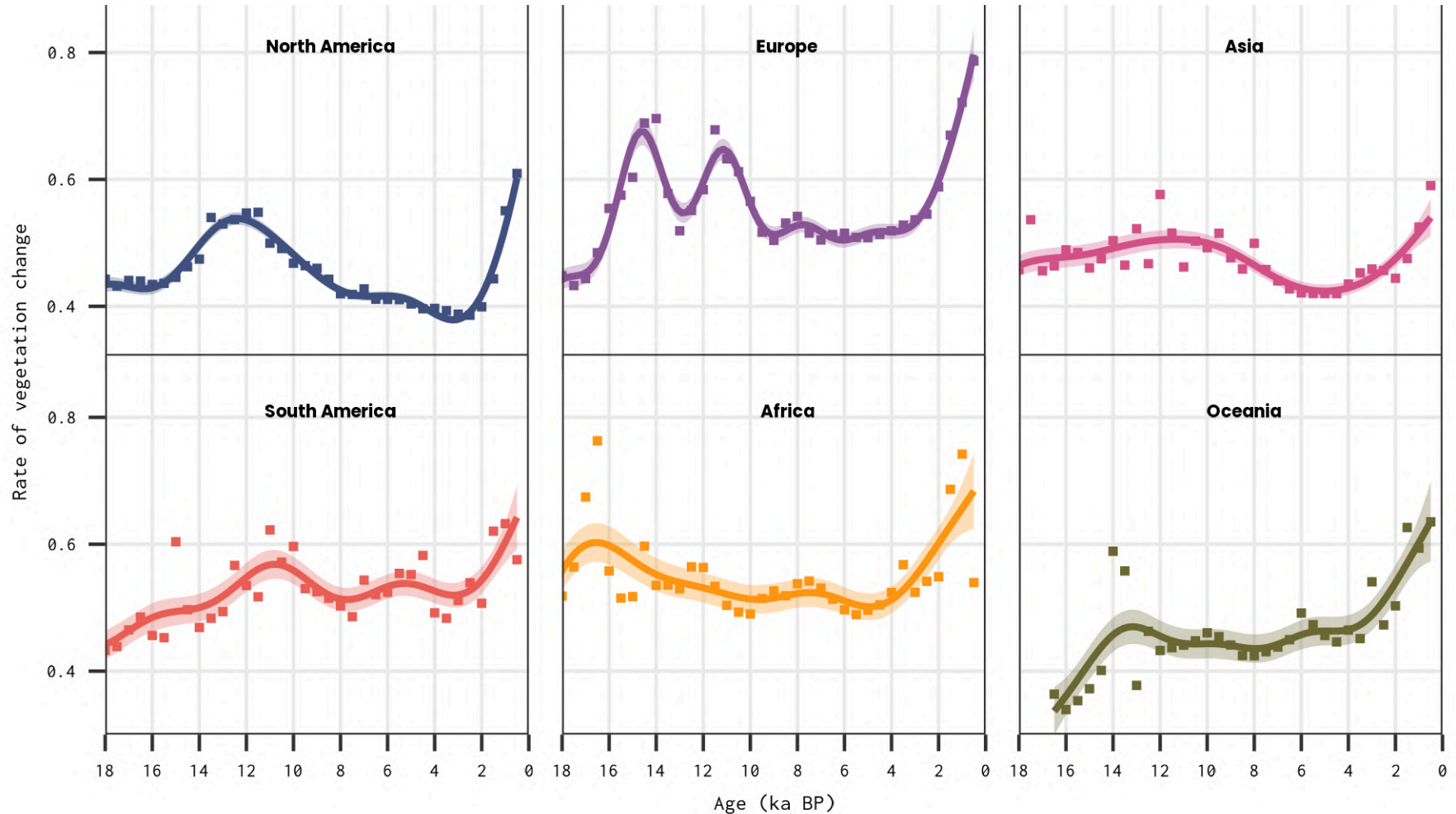
Global rates of vegetation change



Adapted from Mottl & Flantua et al. ([2021](#)) *Science*



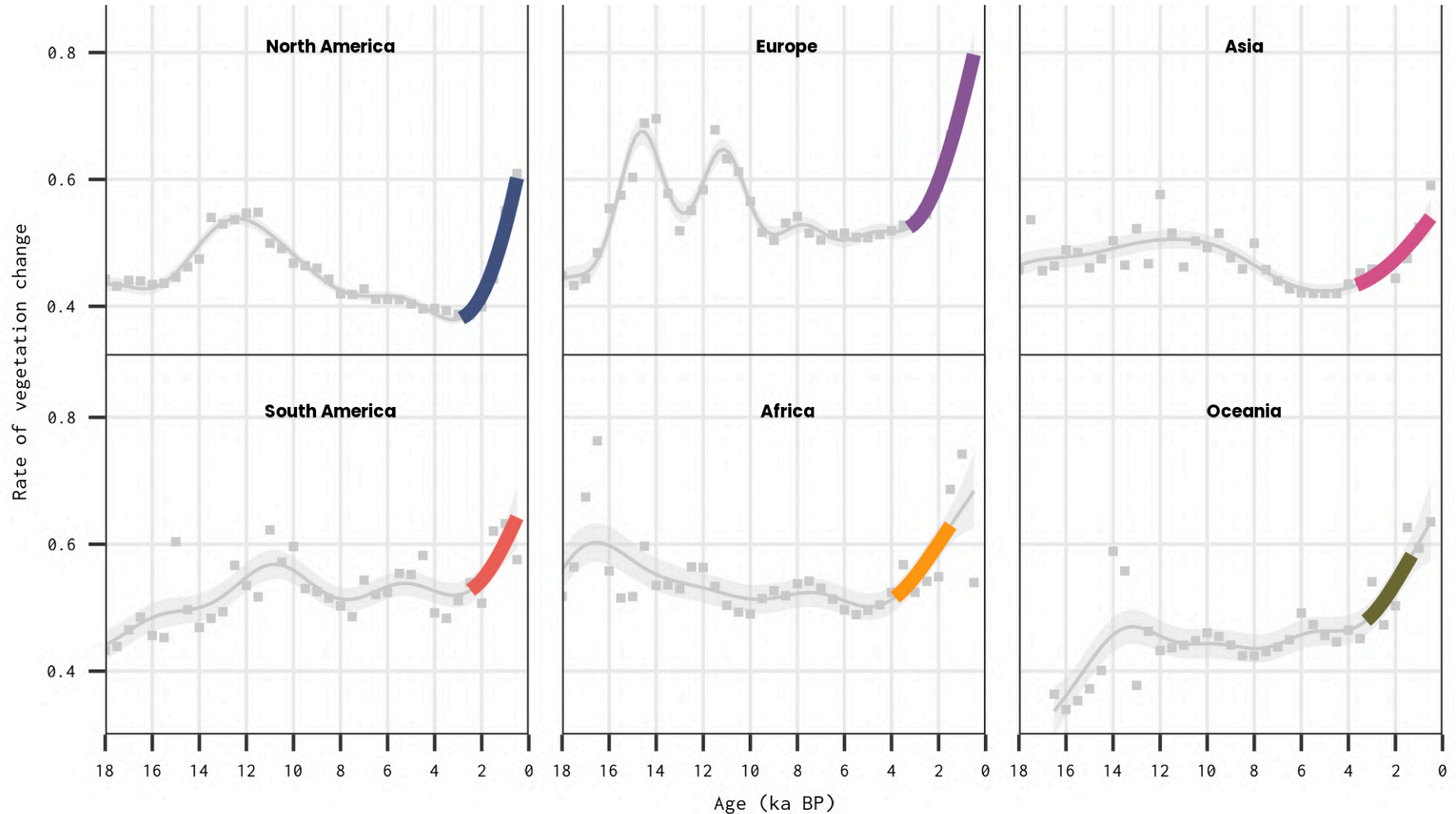
Global rates of vegetation change



Adapted from Mottl & Flantua et al. ([2021](#)) *Science*



Global rates of vegetation change



Adapted from Mottl & Flantua et al. ([2021](#)) *Science*





HOME > SCIENCE > VOL. 372, NO. 6544 > GLOBAL ACCELERATION IN RATES OF VEGETATION CHANGE OVER THE PAST 18,000 YEARS

| REPORT

Global acceleration in rates of vegetation change over the past 18,000 years

ONDŘEJ MOTTL , SUZETTE G. A. FLANTUA , KUBER P. BHATTA , VIVIAN A. FELDE , THOMAS GIESECKE , SIMON GORING , ERIC C. GRIMM, SIMON HABERLE , HENRY HOOGHIEMSTRA, SARAH IVORY , PETR KUNEŠ , STEFFEN WOLTERS , ALISTAIR W. R. SEDDON , AND JOHN W. WILLIAMS

SCIENCE • 21 May 2021 • Vol 372, Issue 6544 • pp. 860-864 • DOI: [10.1126/science.abg1685](https://doi.org/10.1126/science.abg1685)

DOI [10.1126/science.abg1685](https://doi.org/10.1126/science.abg1685)

Mottl & Flantua et al. ([2021](#)) *Science*



Continental Patterns

We do not have to stop at single
ecosystem property (e.g., RoC)

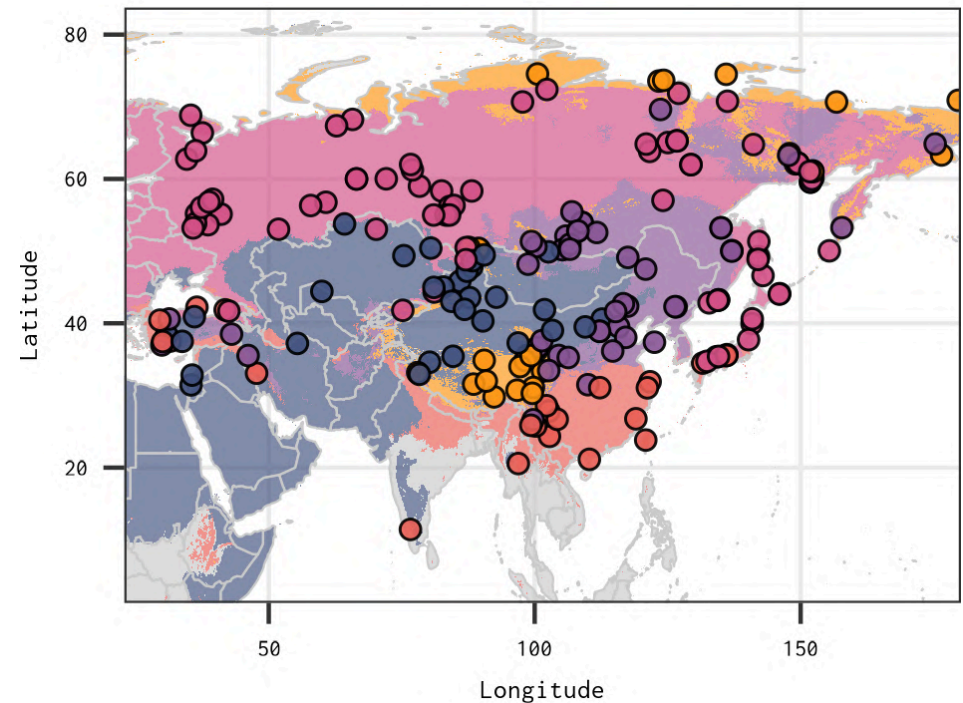


Continental Patterns

We do not have to stop at single ecosystem property (e.g., RoC)

Asia as a case study spanning diverse climates and vegetation types

Asia Case Study



Adapted from Bhatta et al. ([2023](#)) *Frontiers in Ecology and Evolution*



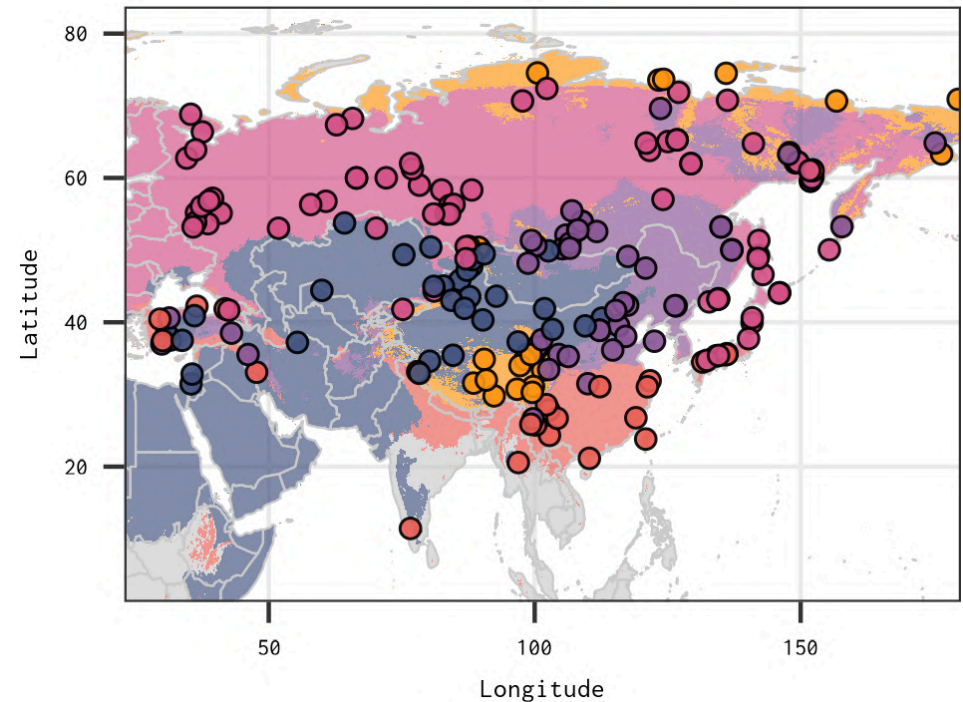
Continental Patterns

We do not have to stop at single ecosystem property (e.g., RoC)

Asia as a case study spanning diverse climates and vegetation types

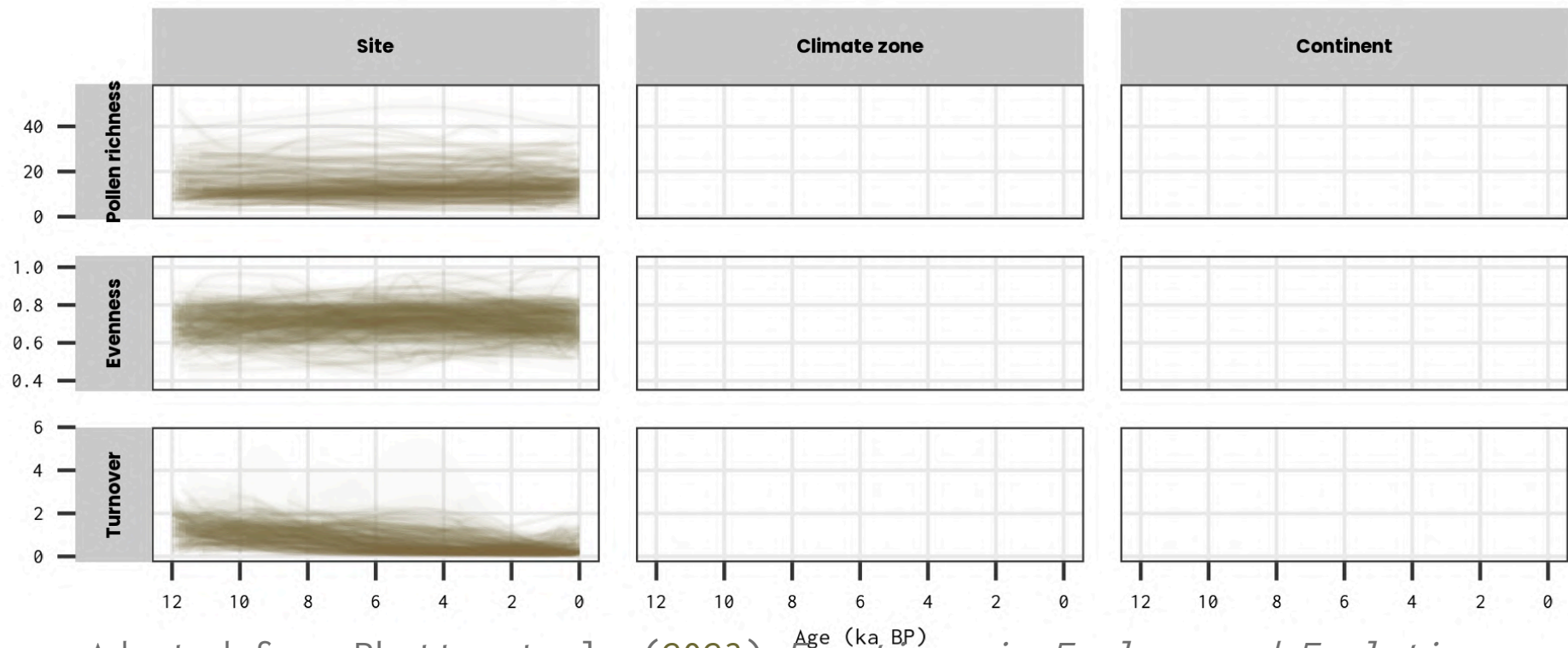
Can we identify consistent continental trend of vegetation change across Asia during the Holocene?

Asia Case Study



Exploring spatio-temporal patterns of palynological changes in Asia during the Holocene

 Kuber P. Bhatta^{1†}
 Ondřej Mottl^{1,2†}
 Vivian A. Felde^{1,2†}
 Suzette G. A. Flantua^{1,2†}
 Hilary H. Birks^{1,2†}
 Xianyong Cao^{3†}
 Fahu Chen^{3†}
 John-Arvid Grytnes^{1†}
 Alistair W. R. Seddon^{1,2†}
 Harry John B. Birks^{1,2,4†}

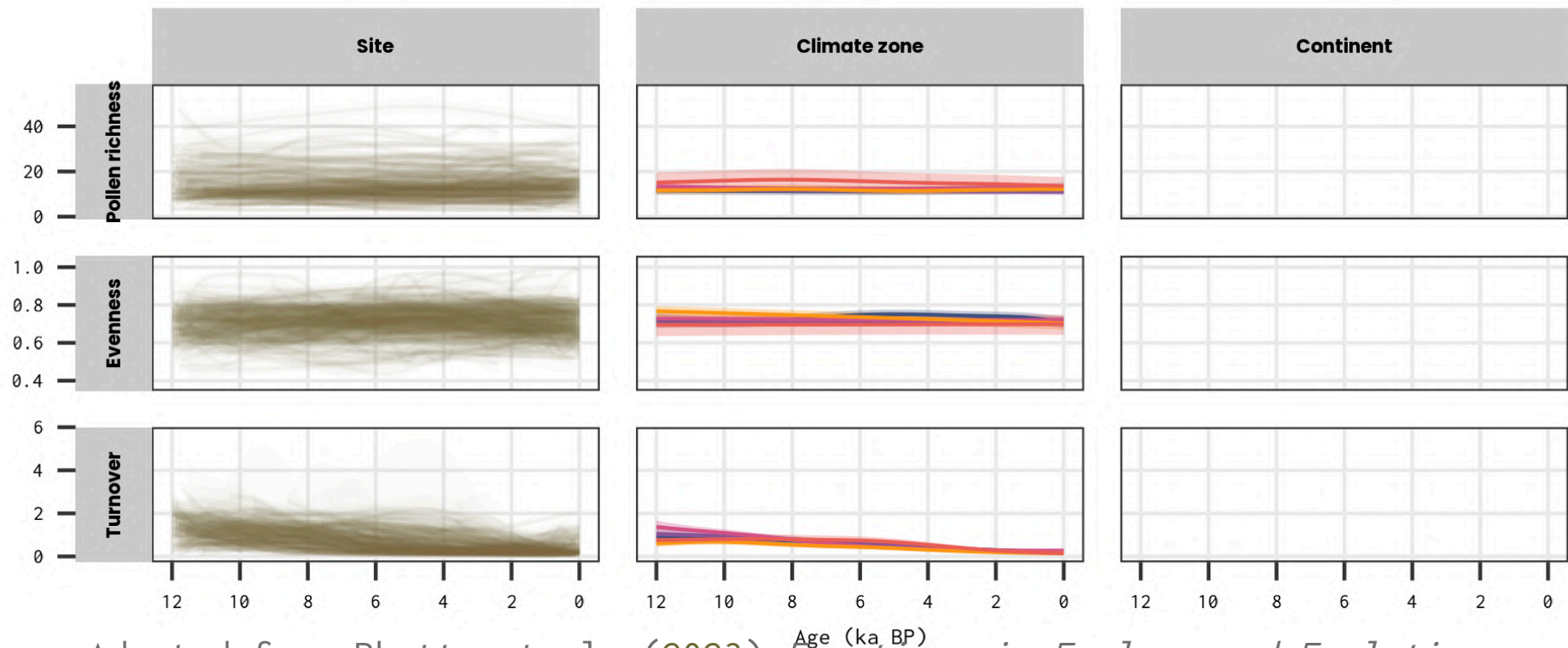


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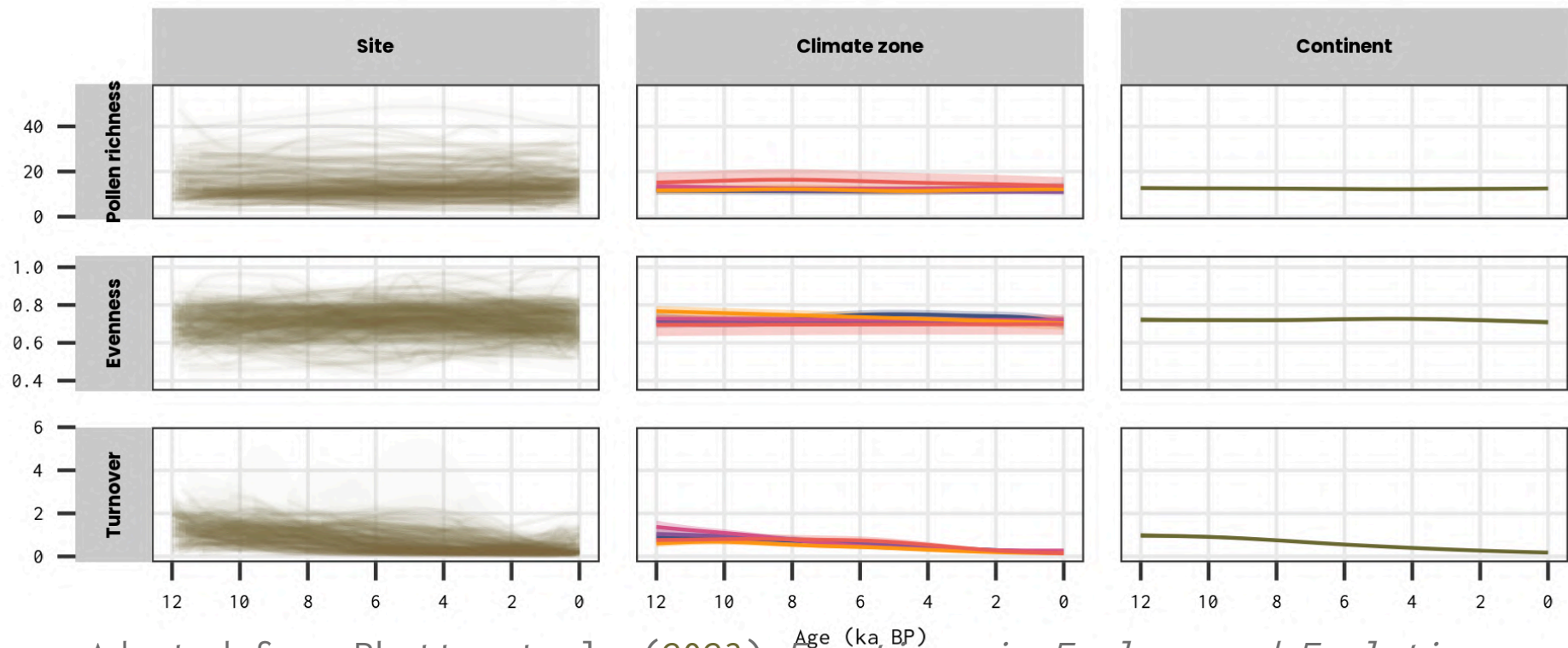


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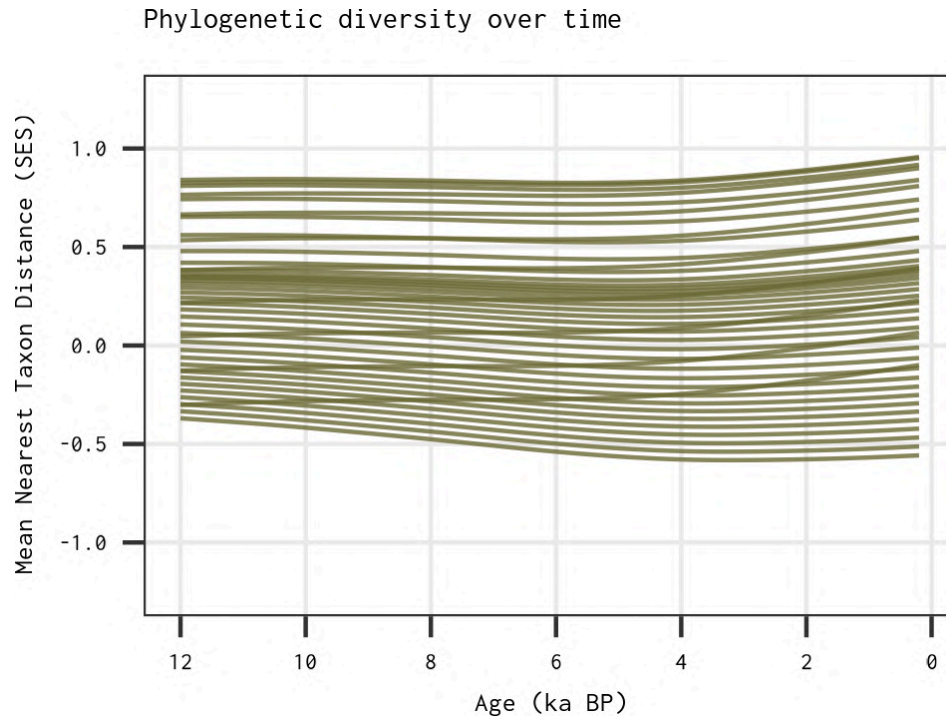
Adapted from Bhatta et al. (2023) *Frontiers in Ecology and Evolution*



Latitudinal gradients in the phylogenetic assembly of angiosperms in Asia during the Holocene

Kuber P. Bhatta , Ondřej Mottl, Vivian A. Felde, John-Arvid Grytnes, Triin Reitalu, Hilary H. Birks, H. John B. Birks & Ole R. Vetaas

[Scientific Reports](#) **14**, Article number: 17940 (2024) | [Cite this article](#)



Adapted from Bhatta et al. ([2024](#)) *scientific reports*



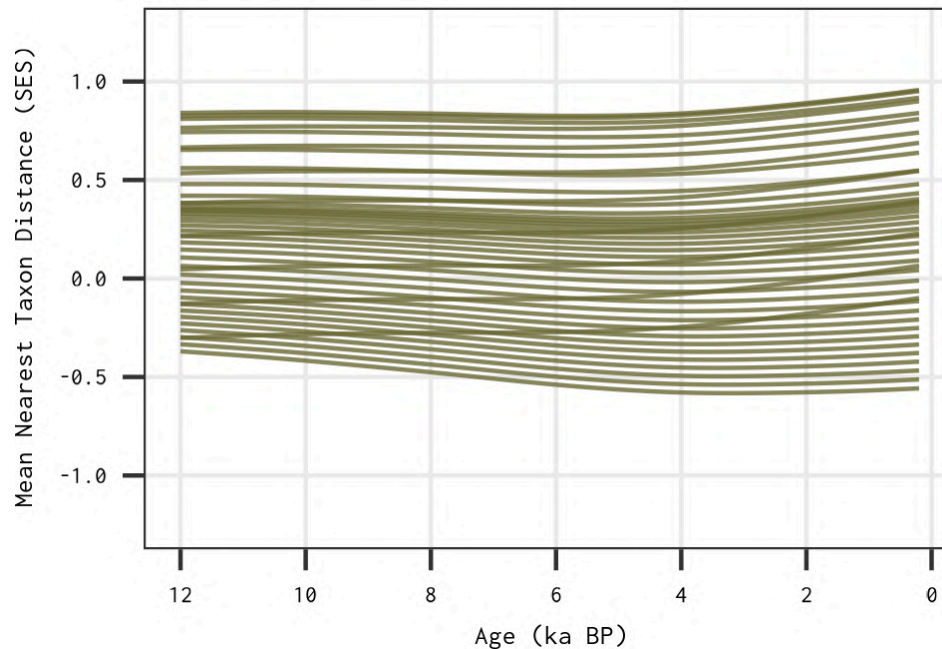
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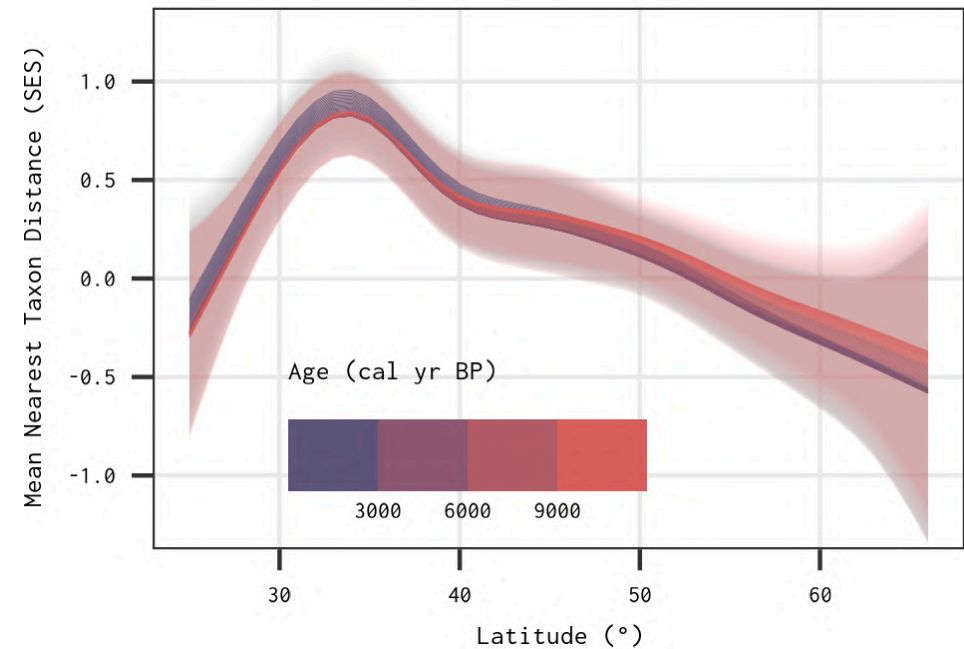
Scientific Reports **14**, Article number: 17940 (2024) | [Cite this article](#)



Phylogenetic diversity over time



Phylogenetic diversity across latitude



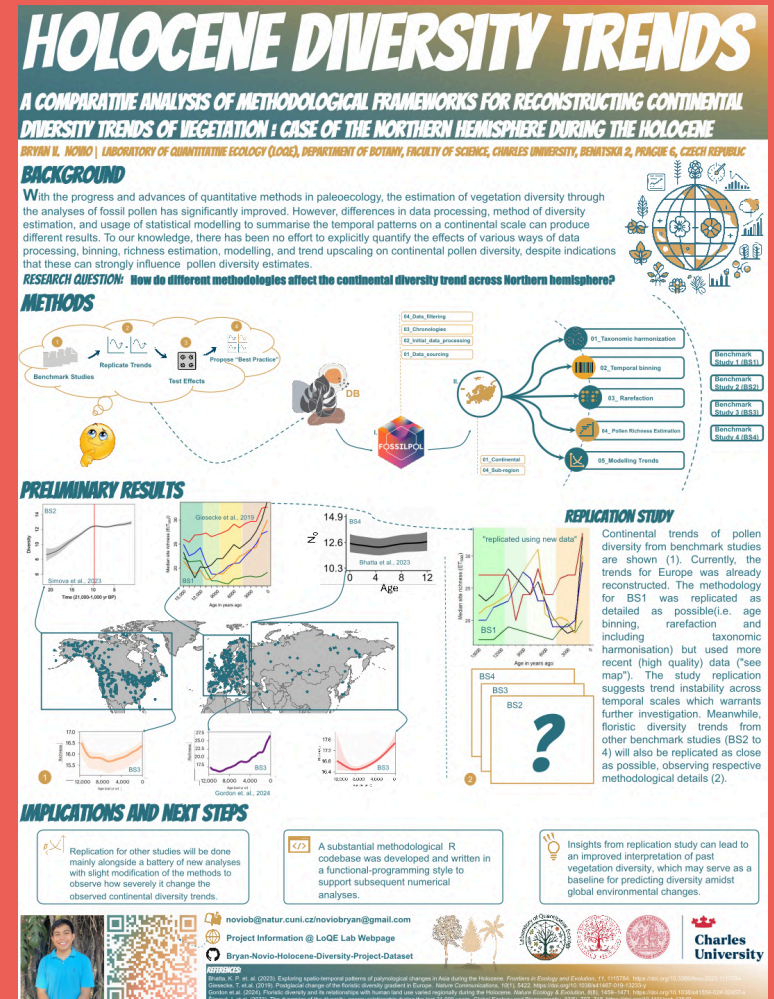
Adapted from Bhatta et al. ([2024](#)) *scientific reports*



Student intermezzo

Poster No. 2006

A Comparative Analysis of Methodological Frameworks for Reconstructing Continental Diversity Trends of Vegetation





Functional Traits

- Taxonomic identity $\neq$ ecological function
- Functional ecology allow to generalise across taxa, regions, and time
- Link between palaeoecological proxies and functional traits



Functional Traits



- Taxonomic identity $\neq$ ecological function
- Functional ecology allow to generalise across taxa, regions, and time
- Link between palaeoecological proxies and functional traits



REVIEW | Open Access | CC BY

Trait-based approaches as ecological time machines: Developing tools for reconstructing long-term variation in ecosystems

Kerry A. Brown, M. Jane Bunting, Fabio Carvalho, Francesco de Bello, Luke Mander, Katarzyna Marcisz, Ondrej Mottl, Triin Reitalu, Jens-Christian Svenning

First published: 22 August 2023 | <https://doi.org/10.1111/1365-2435.14415> |

VIEW METRICS

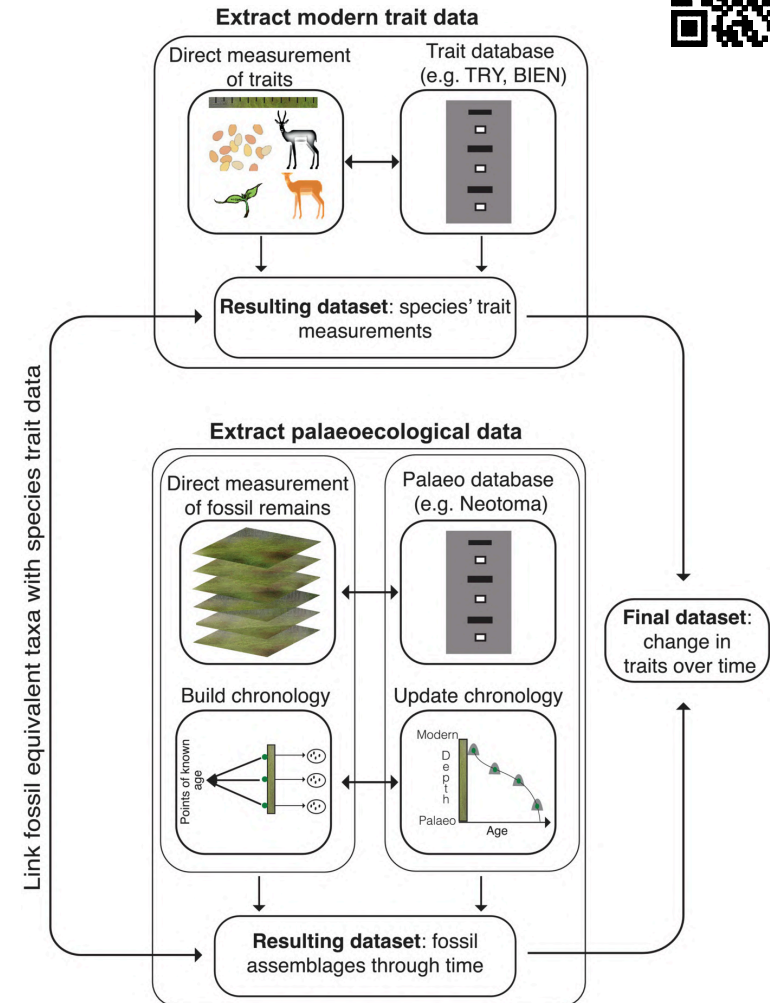


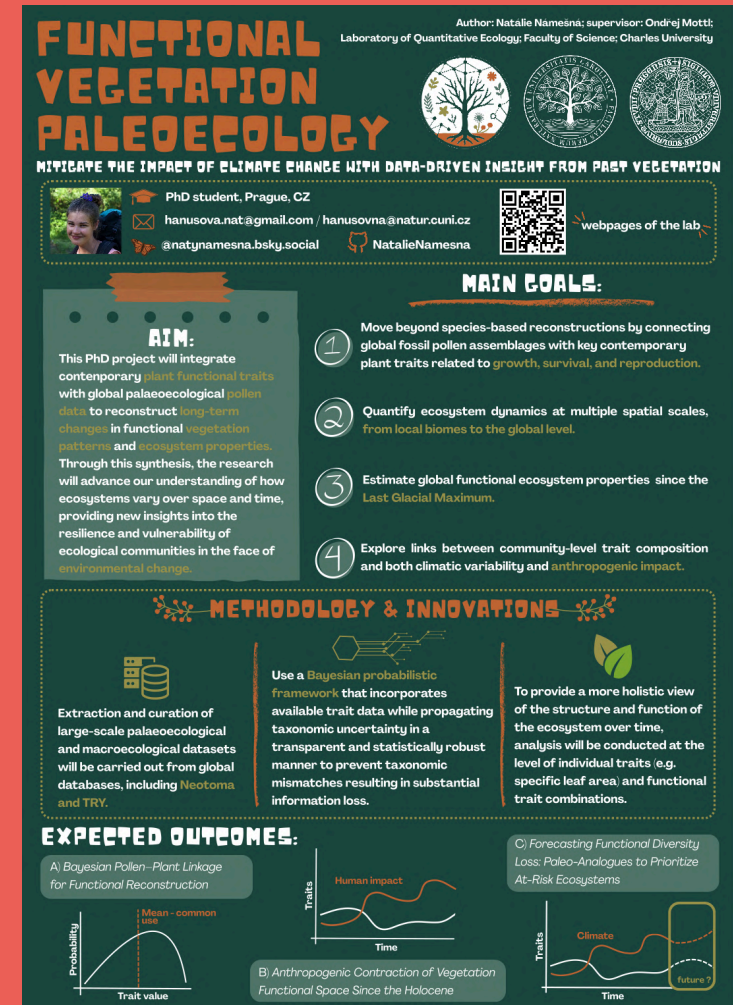
Figure 1 from Brown et al. (2023) *Functional Ecology*



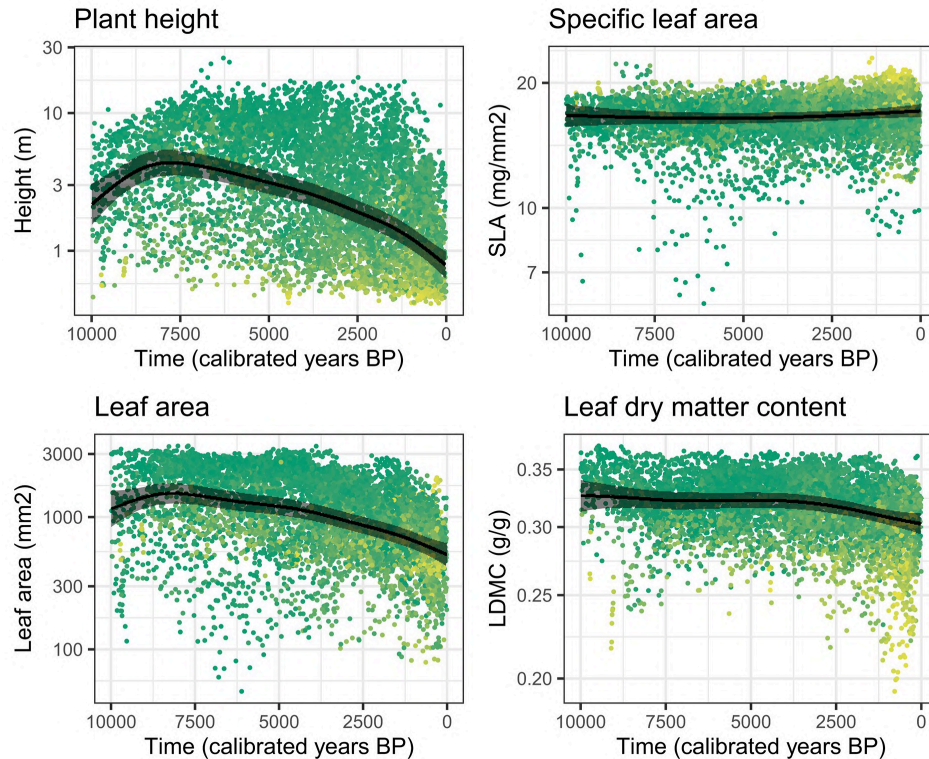
Student intermezzo

Poster No. 2005

Functional Vegetation Paleoecology: Mitigate the impact of climate change with data-driven insight from past vegetation



Traits in time



LETTER | [Open Access](#) | [CC](#) [i](#)

Pollen-based reconstruction reveals the impact of the onset of agriculture on plant functional trait composition

[Annegreet Veeken](#) ✉ [Maria J. Santos](#), [Suzanne McGowan](#), [Althea L. Davies](#), [Franziska Schrod](#)

First published: 11 July 2022 | <https://doi.org/10.1111/ele.14063> | [VIEW METRICS](#)

Editor: John Williams

Example for subcontinental scale **integration of functional traits** with **fossil pollen** data

Figure 4 from Veeken et al. (2022) *Ecology Letters*



Data Integration

Photo by [panumas nikhomkhai](#) from Pexels



Denmark example

*How has vegetation in **Denmark** remained **functionally stable** under **climate** change from the **LGM** to the **present**?*



Denmark example

*How has vegetation in **Denmark** remained **functionally stable** under **climate** change from the **LGM** to the **present**?*

Data Needs

- Fossil pollen and contemporary vegetation plots
- Functional traits (e.g. height, SLA, seed mass)
- Climate data (past and contemporary)



Denmark example

*How has vegetation in **Denmark** remained **functionally stable** under **climate** change from the **LGM** to the **present**?*

Data Needs

- Fossil pollen and contemporary vegetation plots
- Functional traits (e.g. height, SLA, seed mass)
- Climate data (past and contemporary)

Obstacles

- ✗ Several data sources (formats, tools),
- ✗ Taxonomies mismatch across datasets
- ✗ Technically challenging (with limited reproducibility)



VegVault + {vaultkeeper}



*How has vegetation in **Denmark** remain **functionally stable** under **climate** change from the **LGM** to the **present**?*

With few lines of code, you can get the data you need to answer that!



```
1 data_denmark ←
2   vaultkeeper::open_vault(
3     path = "<path_to_VegVault>"
4   ) ▷
5   vaultkeeper::get_datasets() ▷
6   vaultkeeper::select_dataset_by_geo(
7     lat_lim = c(54.5, 58.0),
8     long_lim = c(8.0, 13.0)
9   ) ▷
10  vaultkeeper::get_samples() ▷
11  vaultkeeper::select_samples_by_age(
12    age_lim = c(0, 20000) # 20,000 BP
13  ) ▷
14  vaultkeeper::get_taxa(
15    classify_to = "genus"
16  ) ▷
17  vaultkeeper::get_abiotic_data() ▷
18  vaultkeeper::get_traits(
19    classify_to = "genus"
20  ) ▷
21  vaultkeeper::extract_data()
```



VegVault database



scientific data

[nature](#) > [scientific data](#) > [data descriptors](#) > [article](#)

Data Descriptor | [Open access](#) | Published: 05 December 2025

VegVault dataset: linking global paleo-, and neo-vegetation data with functional traits and abiotic drivers

[Ondřej Mottl](#) ✉, [Franka Gaiser](#), [Irena Šímová](#) & [Suzette G. A. Flantua](#)

- A global SQLite database linking interdisciplinary plot-based vegetation data!
- Links to functional traits, climate variables, and soil properties
- Built for exploring biodiversity dynamics across time & space
- Open Source & Reproducible
- Learn more: bit.ly/VegVault



VegVault database



~110 GB | 32 tables & 87 variables | 480,000+ Datasets | 13M+ Samples | 110,000+ Taxa | 11M+ Trait values | 8 Abiotic variables



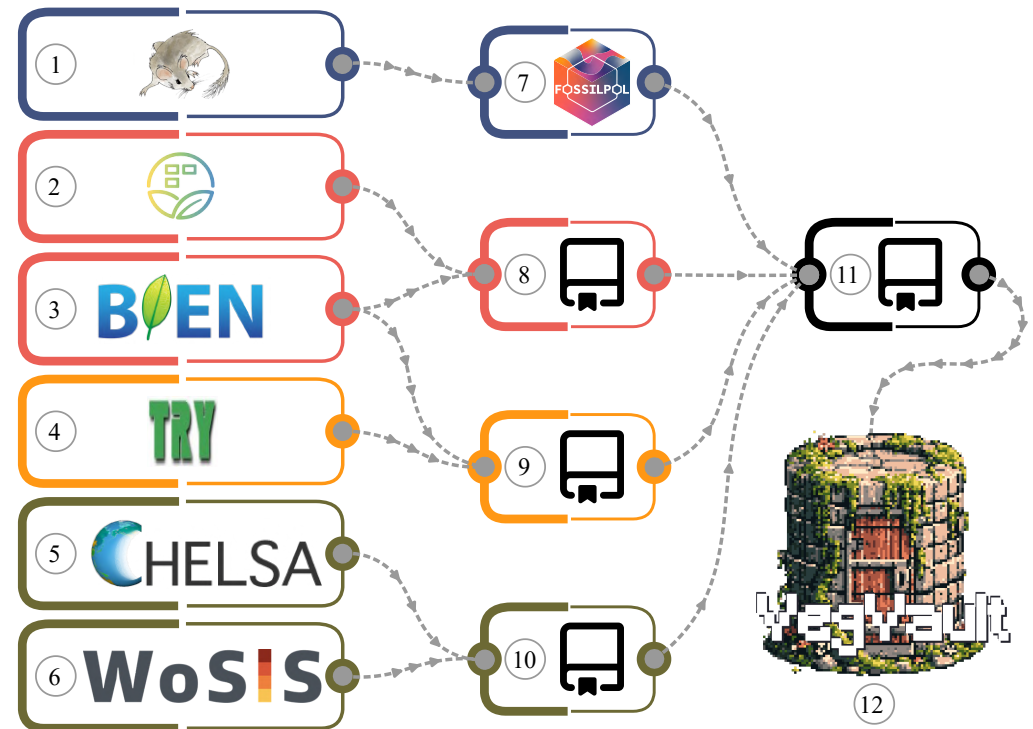
VegVault database



~110 GB | 32 tables & 87 variables | 480,000+ Datasets | 13M+ Samples | 110,000+ Taxa | 11M+ Trait values | 8 Abiotic variables

Data sources

-  **Paleoecological records** (*Neotoma*, *FOSSILPOL*)
-  **Contemporary vegetation** (*sPlotOpen*, *BIEN*)
-  **Functional traits** (*BIEN*, *TRY*)
-  **Climate & soil data** (*CHELSEA*, *WoSIS*)



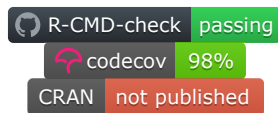
{vaultkeepr} package



An Open Source R package 📦 - Your key 🔑 to **VegVault**



- ✓ No SQL required - just load & go!
- ✓ Filter by taxa, traits, time & space
- ✓ Tidyverse-compatible interface
- ✓ Directly usable in R for analysis
- 🔗 Learn more: bit.ly/vaultkeepr



VegVault database



◆ Key Innovations

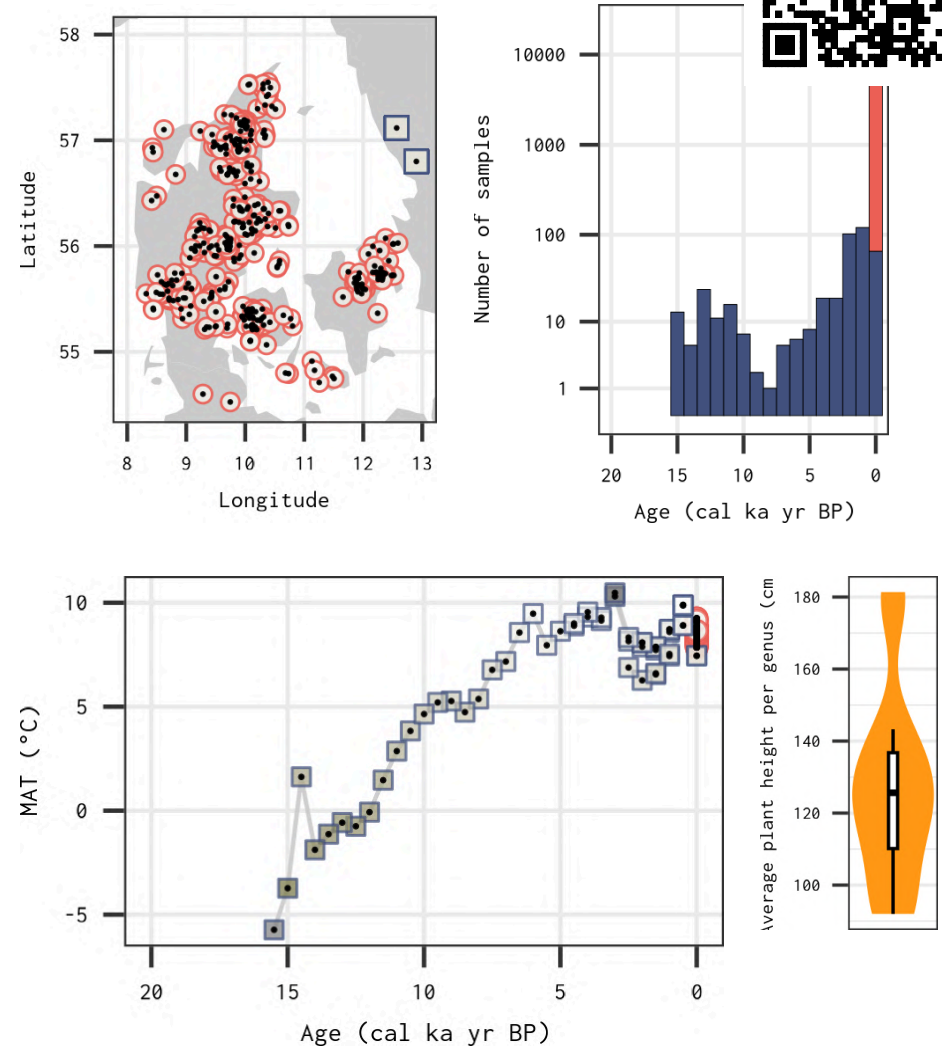
- Integration of interdisciplinary vegetation data into a single database
- Linking vegetation data with functional traits and abiotic variables
- User-friendly R package `{vaultkeeper}` for data access and extraction
- Open Source & Reproducible workflows for vegetation research



VegVault database

Key Innovations

- Integration of interdisciplinary vegetation data into a single database
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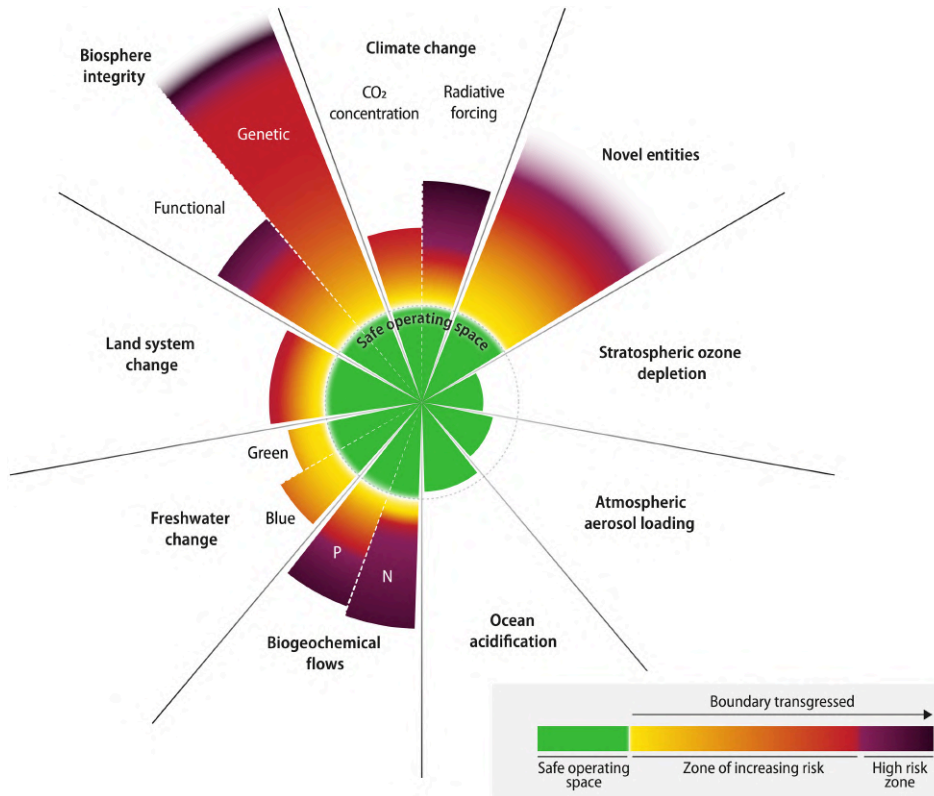
Planetary Boundaries



Photo by [Markus Spiske](#) from Pexels



Planetary Boundaries



ScienceAdvances

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Earth beyond six of nine planetary boundaries

KATHERINE RICHARDSON , WILL STEFFEN, WOLFGANG LUCHT, JØRGEN BENDTSEN , SARAH E. CORNELL , JONATHAN F. DONGES , MARKUS DRÜKE

INGO FETZER , GOVINDASAMY BALA , [...], AND JOHAN ROCKSTRÖM +19 authors [Authors Info & Affiliations](#)

SCIENCE ADVANCES • 13 Sep 2023 • Vol 9, Issue 37 • DOI: 10.1126/sciadv.adh2458

Richardson et al. (2023) *Science Advances*



From Paleo to Policy



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From Paleo to Policy



- Paleoecology offers long-term baselines for historical ranges of variability



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From Paleo to Policy



- Paleoecology offers long-term baselines for historical ranges of variability
- RAD (resist/accept/direct) framework for integrating paleoecological data into policy and decision-making
- Even if the past is an imperfect analogue, it is still essential for bounding plausible variability and diagnosing novelty.



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Exploring the Interface Between Planetary Boundaries and Palaeoecology

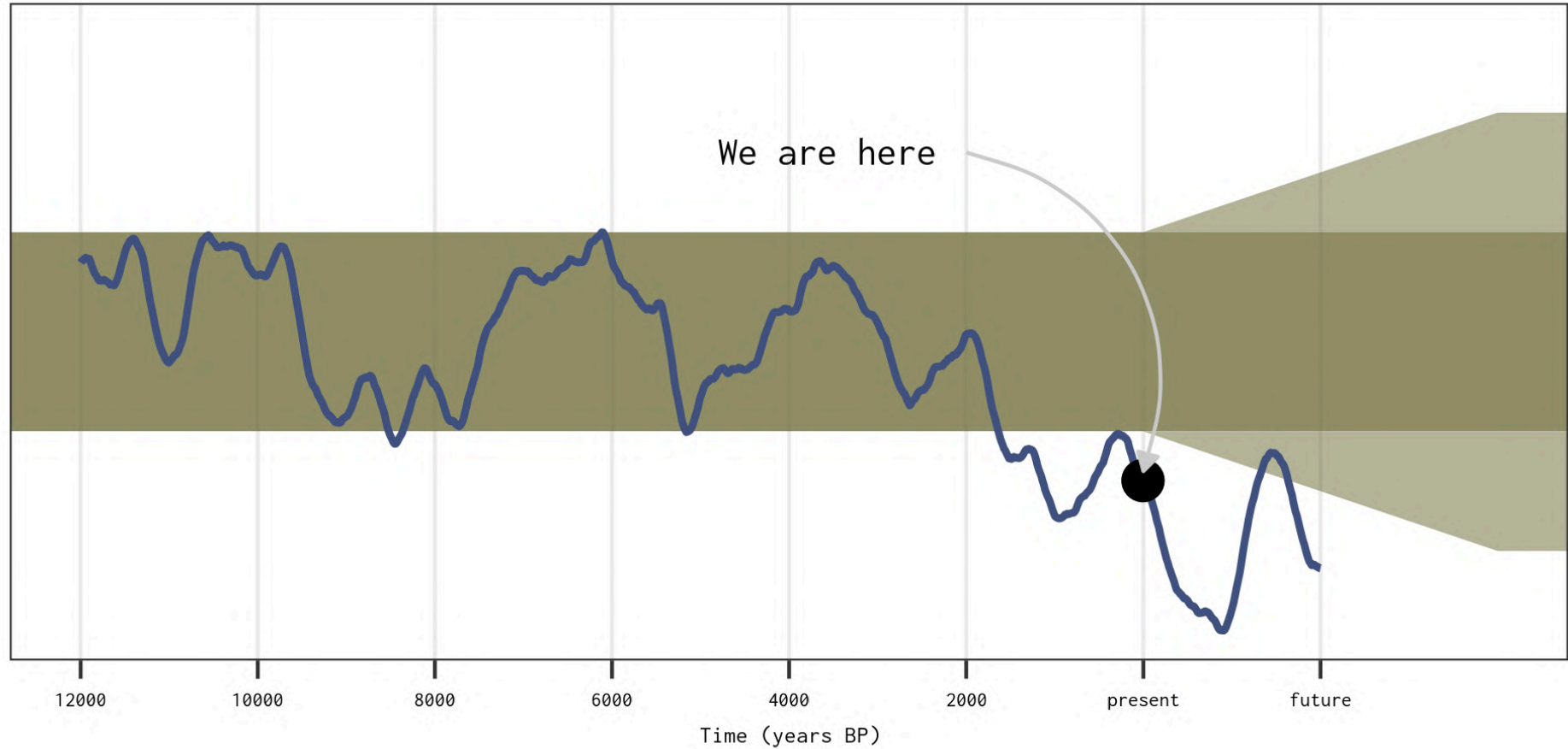
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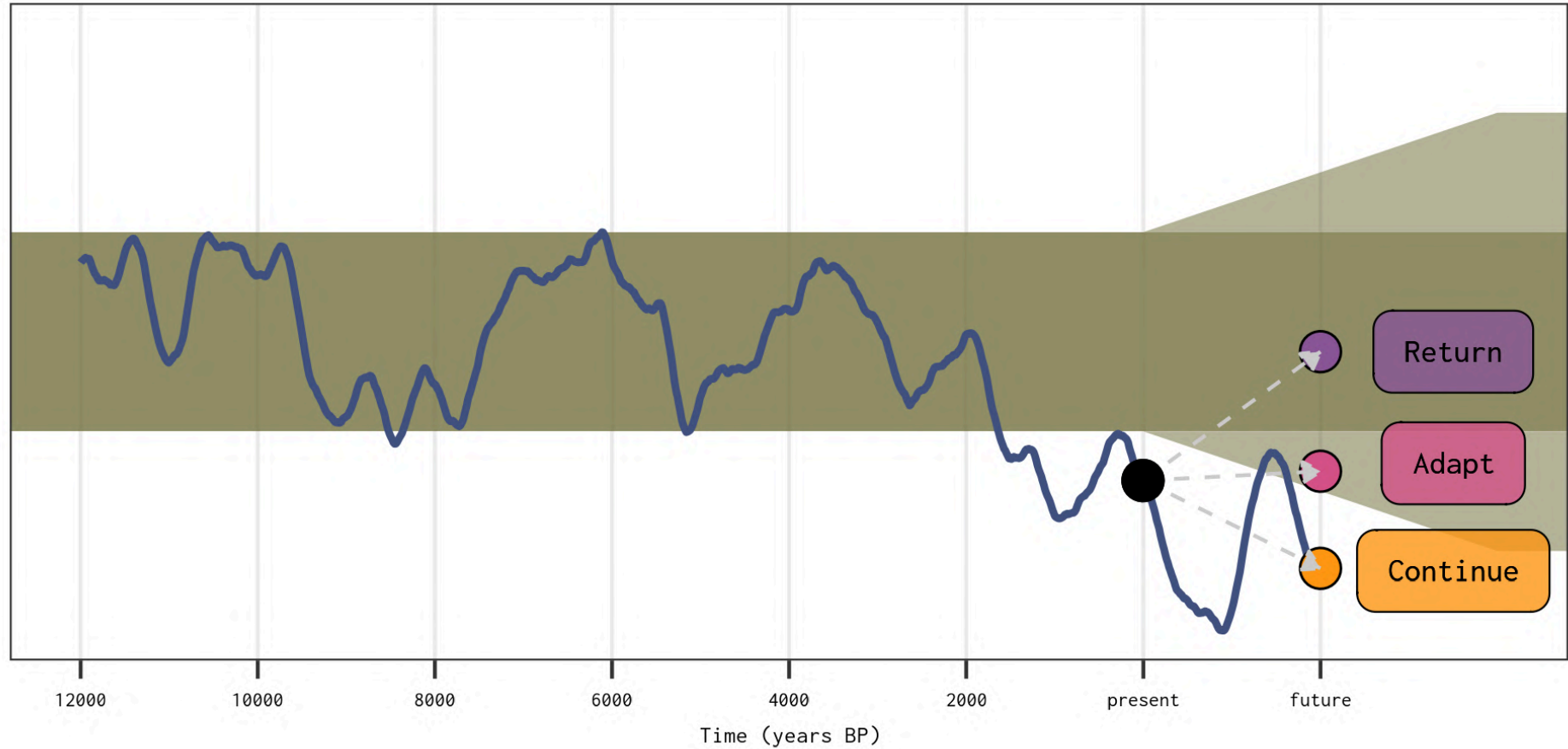
From Paleo to Policy



Gillson et al. ([2025](#)) *Global Change Biology*



From Paleo to Policy



Gillson et al. ([2025](#)) *Global Change Biology*



The time is ripe ... 👍

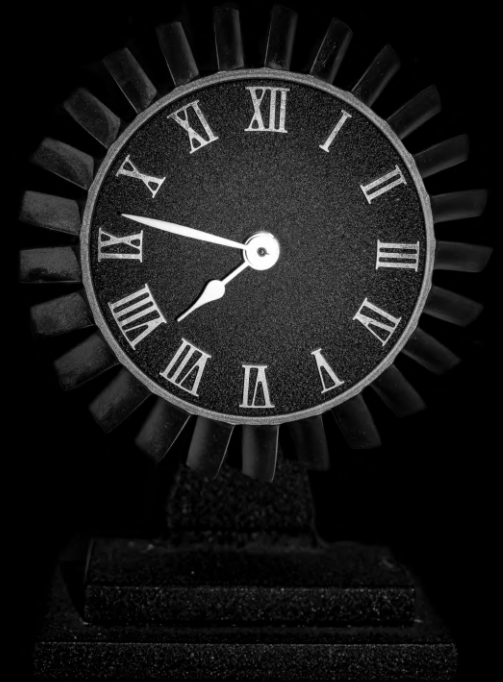


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The time is ripe ... 👍

- Global (integrated) ecological databases spanning large spatio-temporal scales



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The time is ripe ... 👍

- Global (integrated) ecological databases spanning large spatio-temporal scales
- Reproducible workflows for data access

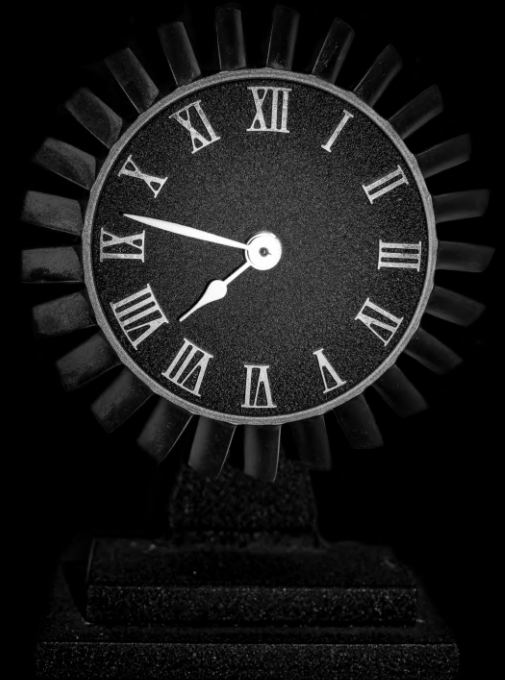


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- Ways to study various facets of biodiversity (taxonomic, functional, phylogenetic)

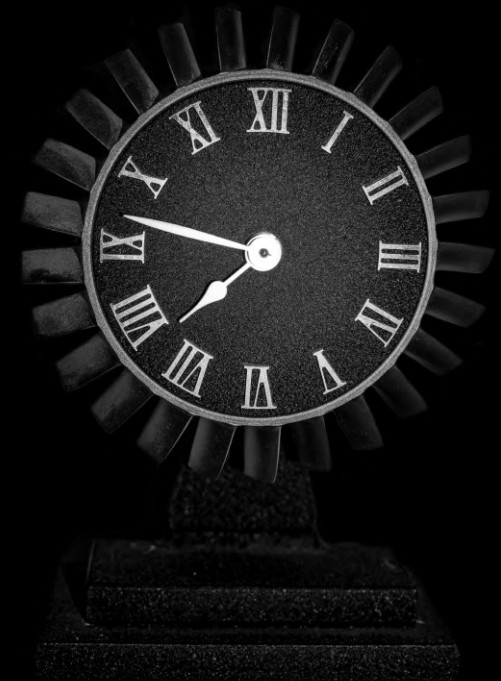


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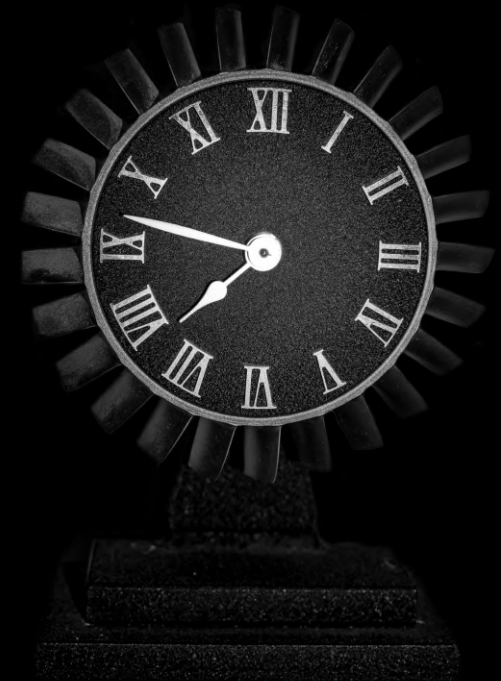


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The time is ripe ... 👍

- Global (integrated) ecological databases spanning large spatio-temporal scales
- Reproducible workflows for data access
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- Statistical methods to handle complex hierarchical data structures
- Computational power and Open Source tools for uncertainty-incorporating analysis

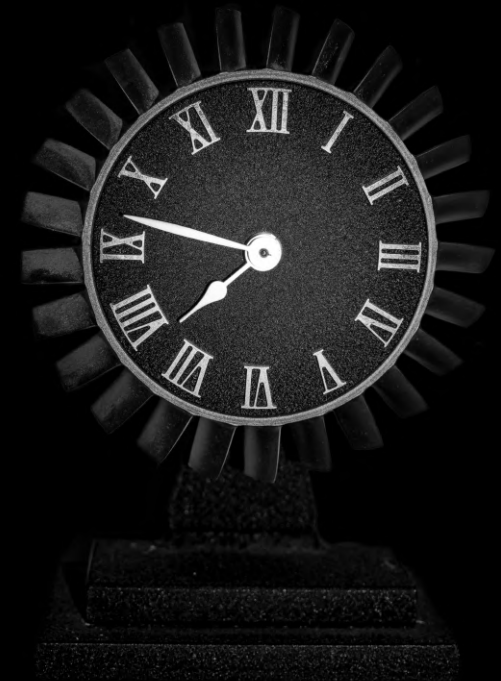


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***Paleoecological data is ready to inform
biodiversity-conservation and rewilding
actions!***



Photo by [Tudor Sorin](#) from Pexels



This presentation

is publically available!



Code |



Slides



Estimating Vegetation Change from Fossil Pollen to Planetary Boundaries

A Global, Long-Term Synthesis Using Big Data

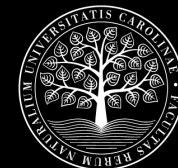


-  [ondrej.mottl\(at\)natur.cuni.cz](mailto:ondrej.mottl(at)natur.cuni.cz)
-  ondrejmottl.bsky.social
-  [Github](https://github.com)
-  [ORCID](https://orcid.org)
-  [Personal webpage](https://ondrej.mottl.cz)



 Ondřej Mottl

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